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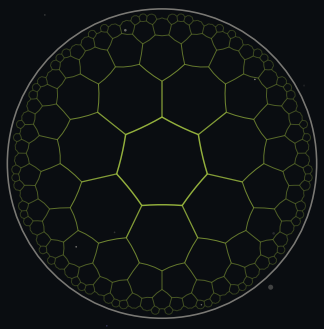


The Law of the *Dead*

Necronomics, the Merciful Aperture, and the Autoimmune Cosmos in the Fiction of H. P. Lovecraft

ΝΕΚΡΟΣ · ΝΟΜΟΣ · ΕΙΚΩΝ

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That is not dead which can eternal lie,
And with strange aeons even death may die.

H. P. LOVECRAFT · "THE NAMELESS CITY" · 1921

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the fiction, essays, and correspondence of Howard Phillips Lovecraft (1890–1937) constitute not a loose assemblage of weird tales ornamented by a private mythology, but a rigorous, if unsystematized, speculative theory of knowledge, which it names *necronomics*. Taking its point of departure from Lovecraft's own philologically erroneous gloss of the *Necronomicon* as "an image of the law of the dead," the study reconstructs the *nomos* of the *nekros* as the governing principle of his cosmicism: the proposition that what is true is what holds in our absence, so that reality's law is, from the standpoint of the living, a law of the dead.

Part One reconstructs the genealogy of this position across five lineages: Democritean and Lucretian atomism and its late-nineteenth-century mechanist restatements in Haeckel and Hugh Elliot; the Copernican, Darwinian, and relativistic decentrings of the human; the degenerationist and eugenic discourses of the fin de siècle; the pessimist and perspectivist philosophies of Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, Spengler, and Russell; and the weird literary tradition from Poe through Machen, Blackwood, Dunsany, Chambers, Bierce, and Hodgson. Part Two formalizes four structural mechanisms. The first is the *merciful aperture*: human cognition as an evolved protective shield, read through Freud's *Reizschutz*, Uexküll's *Umwelt*, Heidegger's animal "poor in world," and evolutionary epistemology. The second is *correlation as catastrophe*: the documentary narrative form in which synthesis, not the monster, is the traumatic event, read against Meillassoux's critique of correlationism and his figure of the arche-fossil. The third is *counter-mythology*: the Mythos as an inversion of myth's anthropological function as theorized by Blumenberg, Horkheimer and Adorno, Otto, and Jonas. The fourth is the *autoimmune cosmos*: the recurrent anagnorisis in which a defended interior (self, lineage, race, species) discovers itself to have been constituted by the Outside, read through

Esposito and Derrida. This last mechanism resituates Lovecraft's racism as the displacement of cosmic panic onto the social field, rather than as either an incidental blemish or the sole engine of the work.

Part Three situates this apparatus comparatively, constructing a typology of postures toward the law of the dead across philosophical science fiction (Wells, Stapledon, Clarke, Lem, the Strugatsky brothers, Dick, Ballard, Watts, Liu Cixin, VanderMeer, Borges) and across the "weird turn" in contemporary philosophy (Harman, Thacker, Brassier, Meillassoux, Ligotti, Morton, Haraway, Negarestani, Land, Fisher). Part Four synthesizes seven theorems of necronomics and contends that the present, defined by deep-time science, the extinction horizon, the Anthropocene, and the delegation of correlation to non-human computational systems, universalizes the Lovecraftian situation and converts weird fiction into the realism of the age. Methodologically, the study combines source-critical intellectual history, close reading, philosophical reconstruction, and comparative poetics. It concludes by identifying a *Lovecraftian trilemma*, madness, a new dark age, or metamorphosis, that maps with unsettling precision onto contemporary responses to planetary crisis, and it recovers from Lovecraft's documented personal ataraxia an unwritten fourth option, *lucid correlation*, as the ethical horizon of a necronomic modernity.



The Nomos of the Nekros

The Problem: Three Paradoxes and a Single Structure

Lovecraft's oeuvre presents three paradoxes that have organized, and largely arrested, its critical reception. The first is the paradox of the materialist mythographer. The author who, in "Idealism and Materialism—A Reflection" (1919), "A Confession of Unfaith" (1922), and "The Materialist Today" (1926), repudiated every form of supernaturalism, teleology, and spiritual survival, and who described the cosmos as a purposeless play of matter and energy, also produced the most generative invented pantheon of twentieth-century letters, a mythology whose derivative textual volume now exceeds that of many historical religions. The second is the paradox of the serene author and the shattered narrator. Lovecraft described himself as an "indifferentist" rather than a pessimist, insisted that humanity's cosmic insignificance was no occasion for lamentation, and met his terminal illness in 1937 with documented composure; yet his narrators are unmade by precisely the knowledge their author contemplated with equanimity, and the characteristic endpoint of his fiction is the manuscript written on the threshold of madness or suicide. The third is the paradox of the reactionary modernist. The antiquarian who lamented the American Revolution, parodied *The Waste Land* in "Waste Paper" (c. 1923), and located the summit of civilization in Georgian doorways and colonial steeples produced one of the most radically post-humanist cosmologies of the modernist period, together with tales whose

racial panic is sometimes the very affective motor of narratives whose structure dismantles the purity they defend.

The critical tradition has typically resolved these paradoxes by suppressing one of their terms. August Derleth's posthumous systematization of the "Cthulhu Mythos" suppressed the materialism, recasting an indifferent cosmos as a Manichaean contest between benevolent Elder Gods and malign Great Old Ones. S. T. Joshi's monumental reconstruction of the worldview restored the materialism, but has tended to treat the mythology as a transparent allegory of cosmic insignificance whose function is exhausted by its philosophical referent. Michel Houellebecq suppressed the serenity, reading the work as a monolith of hatred, "against the world, against life," with racial loathing as its incandescent core. The speculative-realist appropriation of the 2000s and 2010s elevated style and ontology while frequently bracketing politics, and the political critique that accompanied the retirement of Lovecraft's likeness from the World Fantasy Award in 2015 foregrounded the racism while at times treating the cosmicism as its mere displacement. Each resolution purchases coherence at the price of amputation.

This dissertation holds that the three paradoxes are not defects to be dissolved but the symptomatic surface of a single structure. The materialist writes myths because myth is the only form in which a creature bound to meaning can register a reality indifferent to meaning. The author is serene and the narrator shattered because the fiction dramatizes the gap between two standpoints on one truth: the view from nowhere, which the author occupied in his letters, and the view from somewhere, which his narrators cannot abandon. The reactionary is a modernist because his reaction was the defensive affect of an interior that had already registered, earlier and more acutely than most, the full force of what modernity had disclosed. The name this dissertation gives to that single structure is *necronomics*.

The State of the Question

The history of Lovecraft criticism may be periodized as a succession of rescues. The first, editorial and institutional, was undertaken by Derleth and Donald Wandrei, who founded Arkham House in 1939 to publish *The Outsider and Others*; it preserved the corpus at the cost of a doctrinal distortion whose consequences persisted for four decades. Against it stood the mandarin dismissal Edmund Wilson delivered in *The New Yorker* in 1945, which located

the only genuine horror of the tales in their bad taste and bad art, and which fixed for a generation the image of Lovecraft as an adjectival hack. The first serious counter-reading came from within his own circle: Fritz Leiber's "A Literary Copernicus" (1949) identified the decisive innovation as the relocation of the source of terror from the diabolical to the cosmic, from the Devil to deep space.

The European reception supplied the first academic monograph. Maurice Lévy's *Lovecraft ou du fantastique* (1972) read the tales through a psychoanalytic and mythographic lens attentive to the oneiric logic of verticality and depth. The 1970s brought internal revisionism: Richard L. Tierney's "The Derleth Mythos" (1972) and Dirk W. Mosig's "H. P. Lovecraft: Myth-Maker" (1976) exposed the Christianizing dualism of the Derleth systematization and restored the mechanistic indifferentism of the original. The 1980s and 1990s belonged to Joshi, whose corrected texts, biography, and *H. P. Lovecraft: The Decline of the West* (1990) established the canonical account of Lovecraft as a coherent materialist whose metaphysics, ethics, aesthetics, and politics form a unified and evolving system. In the same year Donald R. Burleson's *Lovecraft: Disturbing the Universe* brought deconstructive close reading to the tales' self-subverting textuality, and Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* theorized the categorically interstitial monster that Lovecraft so often supplies. Tzvetan Todorov had earlier rejected Lovecraft's affective definition of the weird on the ground that it made genre depend on the composure of the reader, an objection this dissertation answers by relocating the Lovecraftian criterion from affect to cognition.

Institutional canonization followed with Joshi's annotated Penguin Classics editions (1999–2004) and the Library of America *Tales* selected by Peter Straub (2005). The ensuing decade produced what may be called the weird turn. China Miéville's introduction to *At the Mountains of Madness* (2005), his "M. R. James and the Quantum Vampire" (2008), and his "Weird Fiction" (2009) proposed the tentacle, a limb without Gothic pedigree, as the emblem of a modernity haunted by the unrepresentable. The Speculative Realism workshop at Goldsmiths in April 2007 and the "Concept Horror" issue of *Collapse* (2008) made Lovecraft the unofficial patron of a philosophical movement, a status consolidated by Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011), Graham Harman's *Weird Realism* (2012), Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy against the Human Race* (2010), Ben Woodard's *Slime Dynamics* (2012), and Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016). In parallel, a politics of reception crystallized around Nnedi Okorafor's 2011 reflections on the World Fantasy Award statuette, the award's redesign in

2015, and a wave of creative counter-writings: Victor LaValle's *The Ballad of Black Tom* (2016), Matt Ruff's *Lovecraft Country* (2016), Ruthanna Emrys's *Winter Tide* (2017), Alan Moore and Jacen Burrows's *Providence* (2015–2017), and N. K. Jemisin's *The City We Became* (2020).

What remains absent from this rich and fractious literature is an account of the *operation* that binds its separate objects. Speculative realism describes an ontology, political criticism diagnoses an ideology, biographical scholarship reconstructs a worldview, and affect theory catalogs a mood. None explains why, in Lovecraft, one and the same narrative mechanism produces cosmic revelation, racial panic, mythic invention, and the peculiar ecstasy of the endings in which narrators cross over. That mechanism is the subject of this study.

Thesis

The central claim may be stated in a single sentence. Lovecraft's work constitutes a necronomics: a speculative theory in which truth is defined as what holds in the absence of the knower; in which human cognition is an evolved aperture whose narrowness is protective; in which horror is the phenomenological signature of that aperture's breach by synthesis; in which myth is re-engineered from a technology of distance into a vector of exposure; and in which every defense of the interior against the Outside terminates in the recognition that the interior was constituted by the Outside.

Seven theorems, developed in Part Four, follow from this claim. The *Theorem of the Nomos* reformulates cosmic indifferentism as a theory of truth: the true is what is invariant under the subtraction of the subject. The *Theorem of the Aperture* holds that the human lifeworld is an ecological niche of ignorance, carved by selection for fitness rather than truth. The *Theorem of Correlation* locates the catastrophe not in the monster but in the synthetic act that assembles dispersed data into an intolerable whole. The *Theorem of the Counter-Myth* describes Lovecraft's inversion of the anthropological function of myth. The *Theorem of Autoimmunity* explains the structural identity of his cosmic and racial horrors and the self-dismantling logic that joins them. The *Theorem of the Thalassal Telos* identifies horror as the censored form of a desire for the Outside, so that xenophobia is the conscious affect of the tales while xenophilia is their narrative destination. The *Theorem of Necronomic Modernity* argues that the present has universalized the Lovecraftian situation.

On the Name: A Philological Excursus

The *Necronomicon* first appears in "The Hound" (written 1922; published 1924). In the pseudo-scholarly "History of the Necronomicon" (written 1927) Lovecraft supplied a mock-philological pedigree: an Arabic original, *Al Azif*, composed around 730 CE by the "mad poet" Abdul Alhazred of Sanaa, its title glossed as the nocturnal sound of insects that folk belief took for the howling of demons; a Greek version by Theodorus Philetas; and a Latin rendering attributed, with conspicuous anachronism, to Olaus Wormius, whose historical namesake Ole Worm lived in the seventeenth century. In a letter of 1937 to Harry O. Fischer, Lovecraft offered an etymology: *nekros* (corpse), *nomos* (law), *eikon* (image), yielding "an image of the law of the dead."

The etymology is false in its particulars and true in its intuition. The terminal *-icon* is not *eikon* but the neuter adjectival suffix *-ikon*, as in *lexikon*, so that a Greek *nekronomikon* would denote a book "pertaining to the *nomoi* of the dead," the customs or ordinances that concern or govern the dead. The error is productive. *Nomos* designates law in the sense of convention, the humanly instituted order, and stands in the canonical sophistic antithesis to *physis*, nature. A "law of the dead" is therefore a paradox, a *nomos* without legislators and without subjects, and this paradox is precisely the form in which *physis* appears to a creature of *nomos*. When the living are subtracted, the order that remains is nature; but to the living who contemplate their own subtraction, that order can appear only as law, a law that no one living made and that no one living will obey. The *Necronomicon* is the book in which *physis* is written in the language of *nomos*: an *eikon*, a representation within culture, of the order that holds outside and after culture.

The antithesis maps with exactness onto Lovecraft's explicit philosophy. His metaphysics is a doctrine of *physis*, a mechanistic materialism in which, as he wrote to Farnsworth Wright on 5 July 1927 in defense of "The Call of Cthulhu," human laws, interests, and emotions possess no validity or significance in the cosmos at large, so that genuine "externality" in fiction requires the writer to forget them. His ethics is a doctrine of *nomos*, a cultural traditionalism in which inherited forms, though cosmically arbitrary, are the only available ground of value. His horror is the moment in which *physis* appears within *nomos*. Necronomics names the discipline of that moment.

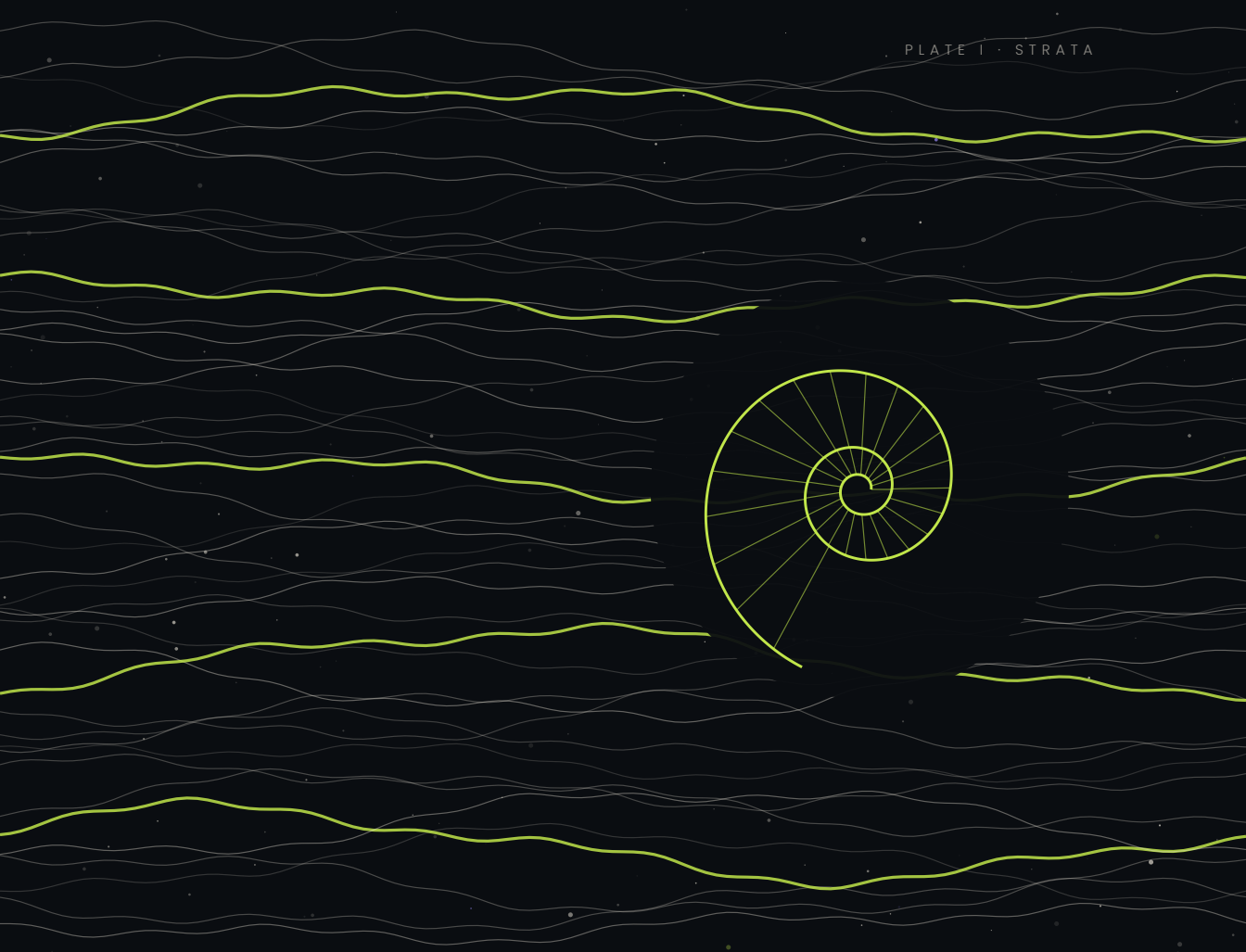
Method and Corpus

The method may be termed speculative philology, and it combines four procedures. The first is source criticism in the tradition of *Quellenforschung*: the reconstruction, from the correspondence, the essays, and Joshi's catalog of Lovecraft's library, of what he demonstrably read. The second is close reading attentive to the formal features through which the work thinks, above all its documentary architecture, its adjectival density, and its rhetoric of the unnamable. The third is philosophical reconstruction, which treats narrative as argument and extracts from the tales propositions that can be stated, tested, and compared. The fourth is comparative poetics, which situates those propositions within a typology of responses to the same predicament across speculative fiction and philosophy.

A strict distinction is maintained between *influence*, which requires documentary evidence of reading, and *affinity*, a structural homology with thinkers Lovecraft did not or could not have read. Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), Peter Wessel Zapffe's "The Last Messiah" (1933), Jakob von Uexküll's study of animal *Umwelten* (1934), Heidegger's lecture course of 1929–30, and Kafka's "The Burrow" (1923–24) are invoked as affinities: independent articulations, within the same historical window, of the structure Lovecraft dramatized. Their convergence is itself evidence that necronomics names something real about the intellectual situation of the interwar decades rather than a private eccentricity. The corpus comprises the original tales from "The Tomb" (1917) to "The Haunter of the Dark" (1935); the principal revisions and collaborations; the sonnet cycle *Fungi from Yuggoth* (1929–30); the essays, above all "Supernatural Horror in Literature" (1927; revised 1933–35), "Notes on Writing Weird Fiction" (1933), and "Some Notes on Interplanetary Fiction" (1934); and the correspondence, whose total volume is conventionally estimated in the tens of thousands of letters.

Architecture of the Argument

Part One, *Genealogies* (Chapters 1–5), reconstructs the lineages from which necronomics was assembled: atomism and mechanism; astronomy, relativity, and non-Euclidean geometry; evolutionary theory and degeneration; the pessimist and perspectivist philosophers; and the weird literary tradition. Part Two, *Structures* (Chapters 6–9), formalizes the four mechanisms of aperture, correlation, counter-myth, and autoimmunity. Part Three, *Afterlives* (Chapters 10–11), situates the apparatus within philosophical science fiction and contemporary speculative philosophy and constructs a typology of postures toward the law of the dead. Part Four, *Necronomics* (Chapter 12 and the Conclusion), states the seven theorems and draws their consequences for a present that has, in the most literal sense, become Lovecraftian.



PART ONE

I Genealogies

01 The Epicurean Inversion
02 Copernican Wounds
03 The Abyss of Descent
04 Philosophers of the Void
05 The Weird Lineage

01

The Epicurean Inversion

Atomism, Mechanism, and the Indifferentist Subject

Lovecraft inherited from ancient atomism both its ontology and its indifferent gods, and he reversed its therapeutic promise: where Lucretius held that knowledge of nature abolishes fear, Lovecraft's fiction demonstrates that, at the scale disclosed by modern science, knowledge of nature is the source of fear. This reversal, here termed the *Epicurean inversion*, is the genealogical root of necronomics.

1.1 *The Atomist Charter*

The first necronomic sentence in the Western archive is a fragment of Democritus preserved by Sextus Empiricus and Galen: by convention (*nomōi*) sweet, by convention bitter, by convention hot, by convention cold, by convention color; in reality (*eteēi*) atoms and void. The fragment is more than an early formulation of the distinction between secondary and primary qualities. It installs the antithesis of *nomos* and reality at the level of perception itself. The qualitative lifeworld, the world of sweetness, warmth, and color in which organisms actually live, is declared a convention of the perceiver, while the real is what remains when the perceiver's contribution is subtracted. Every subsequent materialism inherits this subtraction, and every subsequent horror of materialism is a meditation on what it feels like to be the term subtracted.

Epicurus converted the Democritean ontology into a therapy. Knowledge of nature (*physiologia*) was valuable not for its own sake but because it dissolved

the two great terrors of human life, fear of the gods and fear of death. The gods exist, on the Epicurean account, but dwell in the *metakosmia*, the spaces between worlds, in a blessedness that is untroubled by and uninterested in human affairs; death is the dispersal of the atoms of the soul and therefore nothing to the one who dies. Lucretius gave this therapy its supreme literary form. In the celebrated encomium of the first book of *De Rerum Natura* (I.62–79), when human life lay crushed beneath the weight of *religio*, a Greek first dared to raise his mortal eyes against it, burst the bolts of nature's gates, and advanced in mind far beyond the *flammantia moenia mundi*, the flaming walls of the world, traversing the immeasurable whole (*omne immensum peragravit mente animoque*) and returning victorious to report what can and cannot come to be. Religion is thereby trampled underfoot, and the victory raises humanity to the heavens.

The structure of this passage is the template that Lovecraft would invert term by term: a transgression of the cosmic boundary, a journey of the mind through the immeasurable, a return bearing knowledge, and a therapeutic consequence. In Lucretius the return is triumphant and the consequence is liberation. In Lovecraft the journey is identical and the return is catastrophic.

1.2 *The Mechanist Restatement*

Lovecraft's intellectual autobiography, recounted in "A Confession of Unfaith" (1922), follows a trajectory from a childhood enthusiasm for the *Arabian Nights* and Greco-Roman myth, through an early rejection of Christianity, to a scientific awakening centered on chemistry and, from about the age of twelve, astronomy. The hectographed *Rhode Island Journal of Astronomy* (1903–1907) and the astronomy columns he contributed to Rhode Island newspapers from 1906 onward record a young man for whom the telescope was the primary instrument of metaphysics. The biographical record also preserves a wound: the nervous collapse of 1908, the failure to complete high school, and reported difficulties with higher mathematics that foreclosed a professional career in astronomy. The failed astronomer who could not master the formal language of the cosmos would later make the failure of formal languages before the cosmos his signature theme.

Two texts supplied the adult doctrine. Ernst Haeckel's *Die Welträthsel* (1899), translated as *The Riddle of the Universe* (1900), offered a monism in which a single "law of substance" governed matter and energy and in which the

traditional pillars of theology, a personal God, freedom of the will, and the immortality of the soul, were dismissed as illusions. Hugh Elliot's *Modern Science and Materialism* (1919) offered a more austere formulation in three principles: the uniformity of natural law, the denial of teleology, and the denial of any mode of existence not envisaged by physics and chemistry. Lovecraft adopted Elliot's triad in the early 1920s as a compact statement of his own position, and his essays of the period translate it into a genealogy of belief. In "Idealism and Materialism—A Reflection" (1919) idealism and religion are presented as survivals of the primitive mind's fear and ignorance, a thesis that Lovecraft shared with the anthropological evolutionism of E. B. Tylor and James George Frazer, and materialism is presented as the mature condition of a species that has outgrown its consolations.

It is essential to register what this mechanism excluded. There is no Epicurean swerve (*clinamen*) in Elliot's universe, no spontaneous deviation to ground freedom; there is no ethical telos, no nature that is "for" anything. When Lovecraft later absorbed quantum indeterminacy, he admitted chance into the cosmos but not purpose. His materialism thus retained Democritean rigor while shedding Epicurean comfort, and this asymmetry is the first condition of the inversion.

1.3 *The Inversion*

Lovecraft preserves the atomist ontology and the indifference of the gods while reversing the therapeutic vector. Three transformations explain the reversal.

The first is a transformation of *scale and content*. The Lucretian universe is infinite but ontologically minimal: atoms, void, and their combinations, repeated without end. Its infinity is homogeneous and therefore, in a sense, familiar; every world is made of the same stuff under the same laws. The cosmos disclosed by nineteenth-century astronomy, geology, and biology is infinite and heterogeneous: stratified across billions of years, structured by processes that generate forms of organization, and plausibly inhabited by modes of life and cognition incommensurable with the human. Lovecraft's void is not empty. It teems, and its population is what makes it terrible.

The second is a transformation of *distance*. The Epicurean gods are indifferent because they are elsewhere. Their indifference is a model of serenity, contemplated from afar as an ideal of ataraxia. The Old Ones are equally indifferent, but they are not elsewhere; they sleep beneath the Pacific, persist in

Antarctic cities, colonize Vermont hills, and return when the stars are right. Indifference is a consolation only at a distance. At close range it becomes the obliviousness of the construction crew toward the anthill beneath the foundation, and it is this proximate indifference, not malice, that constitutes Lovecraftian menace. The Epicurean gods, in short, leave the *intermundia*.

The third is a transformation of the *epistemic subject*. Epicurus returns victorious because the knowledge he brings back confirms the sovereignty of the knowing mind: the cosmos is intelligible, its laws are statable, and the one who states them is thereby freed. The Lovecraftian traveler beyond the walls, whether Dyer in Antarctica, Peaslee in the archives of the Great Race, or the narrator who follows Randolph Carter into the tomb, returns bearing knowledge whose content includes the demotion of the knower. The mind that traverses the immeasurable encounters minds that dwarf it, and the Protagorean axiom that man is the measure of all things is refuted not by argument but by acquaintance.

The consequence is a revaluation of the flaming walls themselves. In Lucretius the walls of the world are a prison whose breach is heroic. In "Supernatural Horror in Literature" (1927) Lovecraft defines the true weird tale as communicating a suspension or defeat of "those fixed laws of Nature which are our only safeguard against the assaults of chaos and the daemons of unplumbed space." The laws that Epicurus crossed have become a shield. Chapter 6 will show that Lovecraft never settled this valuation, since in 1933 he would describe the same limits as "galling limitations" that imprison human curiosity; but the direction of the inversion is already clear. Between Lucretius and Lovecraft stands Pascal, the first modern to register the reversal, confessing that the eternal silence of infinite spaces frightened him. Pascal still possessed the wager. Lovecraft inherits the fright without the wager.

1.4 *The Indifferentist Subject*

The inversion structures the fiction; it did not structure the man. Lovecraft's self-designation in his correspondence of 1929 as an "indifferentist" rather than a pessimist expresses a position closer to Epicurus than to any of his narrators: the resultant of natural forces, he argued, cannot be expected to bear any relation to the wishes of the organisms it produces, and there is therefore nothing to lament. The letters record equanimity, frequent irony, and a sustained capacity to contemplate cosmic insignificance without distress.

Two philosophical frameworks clarify this doubled posture. Spinoza's *scientia intuitiva*, knowledge of things *sub specie aeternitatis*, yields in the *Ethics* the highest human beatitude, the intellectual love of God or Nature (*Deus sive Natura*); it was this Spinozan God that Einstein professed in 1929, the same year Lovecraft named himself an indifferentist. Lovecraft's authorial standpoint is Spinozan detachment without Spinozan love. Thomas Nagel's "The Absurd" (1971) supplies the second framework. Absurdity, for Nagel, arises from the collision between the seriousness with which we necessarily live our lives and our capacity to step back and regard that seriousness as arbitrary from a standpoint outside it; the appropriate response is neither heroism nor despair but irony.

Lovecraft distributes the two halves of Nagel's absurd across two persons. The author, in the letters, performs the step back and achieves irony. The narrator, in the tales, is forced into the step back by external evidence while remaining wholly committed to the seriousness it annuls, and he breaks. The fiction is thus a machine for imposing the view from nowhere upon a subject who cannot occupy it. The *indifferentist subject* is therefore double: it names the author who has made his peace with the law of the dead and the character who is destroyed by his first encounter with it. This duality, not any single mood, is the primary datum of Lovecraft's work. The Conclusion will argue that the synthesis of the two, a subject who correlates without breaking, is the tale Lovecraft lived but never wrote.

02

Copernican Wounds

Astronomy, Geometry, and the Collapse of the Transcendental Aesthetic

The Copernican wound in Lovecraft is not positional but transcendental. It is not merely that humanity does not stand at the center of the cosmos; it is that the forms through which humanity intuits the cosmos are not the forms of the cosmos. This chapter traces how Lovecraft converted astronomy, relativity, and non-Euclidean geometry into a narrative refutation of the compensatory recentering that Kant built upon the Copernican decentering.

2.1 *Four Blows to Narcissism*

In "A Difficulty in the Path of Psycho-Analysis" (1917) Freud enumerated three blows that science had dealt to human self-love: the cosmological blow of Copernicus, which removed the earth from the center of the universe; the biological blow of Darwin, which removed humanity from its privileged position among creatures; and the psychological blow of psychoanalysis, which demonstrated that the ego is not master in its own house. Fritz Leiber's designation of Lovecraft as a "literary Copernicus" (1949) captured the first of these, but Lovecraft's fiction inflicts all three at once and adds a fourth, which may be called the *noetic blow*: the demonstration that human cognition is neither the only, nor the highest, nor even an adequate mode of cognition in the

cosmos. The Great Race of Yith, the Elder Things, and the Mi-Go are not simply more powerful than humans; they know more, and they know differently.

The affective history of the first blow already contains the range of responses that Lovecraft would exhaust. Giordano Bruno, in *De l'infinito, universo e mondi* (1584), greeted the infinity of worlds with ecstasy, as the liberation of the mind into a boundless divine fecundity. Pascal, less than a century later, registered the same infinity as fright. Lovecraft adds a third term, horror, which differs from Pascalian fright in its object: Pascal feared the silence of infinite space, whereas Lovecraft feared that the silence was not empty, that the infinite was populated by intelligences for which human existence was not even a topic.

Hans Blumenberg's *The Genesis of the Copernican World* (1975) clarifies what is at stake. The Copernican reform, Blumenberg argues, was an anthropological event whose loss contained a compensation: the observer who can calculate his own decentering is thereby recentered, not in space, but as the subject of knowledge. The philosophical consummation of this compensation is Kant's self-described "Copernican revolution" in the preface to the second edition of the *Critique of Pure Reason* (1787), which reverses the direction of conformity so that objects must conform to our cognition rather than cognition to objects. Humanity loses the center of the cosmos and regains it as the transcendental source of the cosmos's intelligibility. Lovecraft's fiction revokes precisely this compensation. It extends the Copernican decentering from the position of the earth to the position of reason itself.

2.2 *Astronomy as Metaphysics*

The telescope was, for Lovecraft, the primary instrument of metaphysics, and his fiction absorbs astronomical data with the promptness of a journal. "Beyond the Wall of Sleep" (1919) closes by citing the popular astronomer Garrett P. Serviss's account of the nova of 1901 near Algol, lodging the fictional claim within the astronomical record. The trans-Neptunian world of Yuggoth, imagined in the sonnet cycle *Fungi from Yuggoth* (1929–30), was identified in "The Whisperer in Darkness" (written 1930) with the ninth planet whose discovery by Clyde Tombaugh at the Lowell Observatory had been announced in March of that year. The mythology was not merely decorated with astronomy; it was updated by it, in the manner of a research program revising its models in light of new observations.

The refrain that the Old Ones will return "when the stars are right" performs a more subtle operation. It borrows the vocabulary of astrology, in which celestial configurations are signs bearing meanings for human destiny, and silently converts it into the vocabulary of celestial mechanics, in which configurations are physical conditions bearing no meaning at all. The stars are "right" not as omens but as orbital periodicities that open and close windows of causal possibility. The phrase is a miniature of the entire counter-mythology analyzed in Chapter 8: a mythic formula whose content has been replaced by physics while its form continues to address human beings who can hear only form.

2.3 *Relativity, Quanta, and the Modified Materialism*

The confirmation of general relativity by the eclipse observations of 1919 reached Lovecraft as a threat. In correspondence of 1923 he registered the new physics as a further erosion of objective certainty, fearing, in the manner of many lay readers, that it reduced the cosmos to a play of relative perspectives. His subsequent reading corrected the misprision. Relativity is not relativism: it is a theory of invariants, of quantities such as the space-time interval and of laws whose form is preserved under every admissible transformation of the observer's frame. By the early 1930s Lovecraft had integrated the four-dimensional continuum into his fiction, most elaborately in "The Dreams in the Witch House" (written 1932), whose student protagonist studies non-Euclidean calculus and quantum physics and whose text names Planck, Heisenberg, Einstein, and de Sitter. His late letters accept quantum indeterminacy as an enlargement of mechanistic materialism while denying that it readmits teleology or cosmic purpose.

The philosophical significance of this assimilation has been underestimated. Ernst Cassirer, in *Substance and Function* (1910) and his study of relativity (1921), argued that modern physics replaces the concept of substance with the concept of invariant functional relation, so that objectivity becomes identical with invariance under transformation. Robert Nozick generalized the claim in *Invariances* (2001): the objective is what remains invariant across perspectives. Relativity thus formalizes, with mathematical precision, the principle that Chapter 12 will state as the first theorem of necronomics. What holds for every observer holds for no observer in particular; the laws that survive every change of standpoint are the laws that would survive the abolition of all standpoints.

The invariant is the law of the dead in its exact scientific form, and Lovecraft's early terror before relativity was misdirected only in its object. He feared that relativity abolished the absolute, when in fact it purified the absolute of every trace of the human.

2.4 *Non-Euclidean Horror and the Collapse of the Transcendental Aesthetic*

For Kant, space is the pure form of outer intuition, and the propositions of geometry, which for him were the propositions of Euclid, are synthetic a priori truths grounded in that form. It follows that an experience of non-Euclidean space is not merely false but impossible: it could not be an experience at all, since experience is constituted by the very forms it would violate. The nineteenth century dismantled this claim in stages. Lobachevsky (1829) and Bolyai (1832) constructed consistent geometries in which the parallel postulate fails; Riemann's habilitation lecture of 1854 generalized geometry to manifolds of variable curvature; Hermann von Helmholtz, in his lecture on the origin and significance of geometrical axioms (1870), imagined beings confined to curved surfaces who would develop geometries appropriate to their embodiment, and so recast geometry as relative to the situation of the knower. Edwin Abbott's *Flatland* (1884) and Charles Howard Hinton's *Scientific Romances* (1884–1886) carried these speculations into popular fiction, and Henri Poincaré's conventionalism in *La Science et l'hypothèse* (1902) concluded that the choice of geometry is a matter of convenience rather than necessity.

Lovecraft's "non-Euclidean" is scientifically loose, but it is philosophically exact. In "The Call of Cthulhu" (1926; published 1928) the architecture of R'lyeh is described as abnormal and non-Euclidean, redolent of spheres and dimensions apart from ours, and the sailor Parker is swallowed by an angle of masonry "which was acute, but behaved as if it were obtuse." The sentence does not describe an unusual object within experience. It describes a failure of the conditions of experience, a perception in which the form of intuition itself is violated while perception continues. In Kantian terms this is not an empirical horror but a transcendental one: what the sailors witness is the Transcendental Aesthetic breaking down in real time. Helmholtz's thought experiment is here run in reverse. Instead of imagining other beings with other geometries, Lovecraft places human beings inside a geometry built for others and records

what happens to the human form of intuition when it is forced to operate outside its native manifold.

"The Dreams in the Witch House" completes the argument. The Salem witch Keziah Mason is revealed to have grasped, by intuition in 1692, the higher-dimensional angles that Walter Gilman approaches through modern mathematics; the witch and the mathematician are two routes to the same edge of the human manifold. The equivalence is the reverse of the one Arthur C. Clarke would later codify in his third law, that sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic. For Lovecraft, sufficiently alien physics is indistinguishable from witchcraft, and the history of the supernatural is reinterpreted as a history of intermittent, uncomprehended contact with the edges of the transcendental form. Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006) will supply the exact inverse: a species for whom Euclidean right angles are neurologically catastrophic, driven to extinction by the rectilinear architecture of human civilization. Taken together, the two fictions establish that geometry is an ecological parameter of cognition, a species-specific setting rather than a universal form.

A final irony attends the Kantian background. In *Dreams of a Spirit-Seer* (1766) Kant ridiculed Swedenborg and, by extension, every visionary who claimed cognitive access beyond the bounds of possible experience. Lovecraft's fiction is populated by spirit-seers whose dreams are veridical: the sculptor Wilcox, whose bas-relief reproduces a being he has never seen; Peaslee, whose dreams of Pnakotus turn out to be memories; Gilman, whose dreams are journeys. The critical philosophy had expelled the seer in the name of the bounds of reason. Lovecraft readmits him, not because the bounds were illusory, but because the region beyond them turns out to be real and, occasionally, to communicate. The Copernican wound thus becomes the noetic wound, and the question it leaves open, namely where the human forms of intuition came from if they are not the forms of things, is answered in the next chapter by Darwin.

03

The Abyss of Descent

Deep Time, Degeneration, and the Abhuman

Darwinian deep time opens two abysses beneath the human, and Lovecraft explores both. The first descends: humanity is the late product of animal ancestry, and the ancestor persists within the descendant as a latent possibility of regression. The second ascends: the conditions of life itself may be the by-product of prior intelligences for which humanity was never an end. Between these abysses the human appears as a stratum, a transient layer in a sequence that neither began nor will end with it.

3.1 *Deep Time and Stratigraphic Narrative*

James Hutton's *Theory of the Earth* (1788) concluded that the geological record showed no vestige of a beginning and no prospect of an end, and Charles Lyell's *Principles of Geology* (1830–1833) established the uniformitarian method that made such durations the working assumption of the earth sciences. What John McPhee would later name "deep time" is, for Lovecraft, the native element of narrative. The chronologies of *At the Mountains of Madness* (written 1931) and "The Shadow out of Time" (written 1934–35) are measured in hundreds of millions of years; the Elder Things arrive on a young earth, and the Great Race flourishes in an epoch that dwarfs the entire span of hominid existence.

The formal consequence is a distinctive narrative architecture that may be called stratigraphic. The Lovecraftian plot is frequently a descent through layers

whose depth is also their antiquity: the excavation beneath Exham Priory in "The Rats in the Walls" (1923) passes through Roman, pre-Roman, and prehistoric levels; the explorers of the Antarctic city descend through galleries of bas-reliefs that record, stratum by stratum, the history of the Elder Things; Peaslee in the Australian desert descends into the buried archives of Pnakotus. To go down is to go back, and to go back is to leave the human behind. The narrative is a core sample.

3.2 *Descent: The Ancestor as Monster*

Darwin's *On the Origin of Species* (1859) and *The Descent of Man* (1871) made the ancestor an animal, and Haeckel's "biogenetic law," formulated in *Generelle Morphologie* (1866), made the ancestor a presence within every individual, since each organism was held to recapitulate in its development the evolutionary history of its lineage. The combination produced a specifically modern horror of origins, in which the monster is neither demonic nor foreign but ancestral, and in which genealogy is the form of revelation.

"Facts Concerning the Late Arthur Jermyn and His Family" (1920) states the program in its first sentence: "Life is a hideous thing," and behind what we know of it lie hints of truth that make it more hideous still. Jermyn discovers that an eighteenth-century ancestor married a creature from the Congo, a "white ape" worshipped as a goddess, and he immolates himself upon the discovery. The tale fuses evolutionary descent with colonial racial ideology so completely that the two cannot be disentangled, and it is the earliest instance of the autoimmune structure analyzed in Chapter 9. "The Rats in the Walls" radicalizes the pattern. Its narrator, the last of the de la Poer line, restores the family seat and descends beneath it into grottoes where his ancestors bred human beings as cattle. As he regresses into atavistic cannibalism, his speech descends in parallel through early modern English, Middle English, Latin, and Gaelic into inarticulate sound. Language is treated as a stratified fossil, and the collapse of the speaker recapitulates the excavation of the site. "The Lurking Fear" (1922) supplies the degenerative variant, in which the Martense family, isolated in the Catskills, devolves over generations into a swarm of subterranean cannibal creatures.

"The Shadow over Innsmouth" (written 1931) represents the summit of the genealogical horror and inverts Haeckel's law. The "Innsmouth look" advances with age: the individual's development runs not toward maturity but toward the marine phylogenetic past, until the hybrid descendant of human and Deep One

returns to the sea. Ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny backward. Chapter 9 will show that the tale's final pages transform this regression from an object of horror into an object of desire.

3.3 *Degeneration and the Abhuman*

The fin de siècle turned evolutionary theory against progressivism. E. Ray Lankester's *Degeneration: A Chapter in Darwinism* (1880) argued that natural selection could produce simplification as readily as complexity, citing the sea squirt, whose larva possesses a notochord and nervous system that the sessile adult reabsorbs, and warned that civilized humanity might follow the same path. Bénédict Morel's *Traité des dégénérescences* (1857), Cesare Lombroso's *L'uomo delinquente* (1876), and Max Nordau's *Entartung* (1892–1893) generalized degeneration into a medical, criminological, and cultural theory. Kelly Hurley's *The Gothic Body* (1996) has shown how the Gothic fiction of the 1890s translated these theories into the figure she calls, borrowing William Hope Hodgson's term, the *abhuman*: a subject not quite human, marked by morphic variability and the constant threat of becoming other. Arthur Machen's "The Great God Pan" (1894) ends with a body descending through the evolutionary scale into a gelatinous mass; his "Novel of the White Powder" (1895) dissolves its victim into black putrescence; H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) turns class into species with the Eloi and Morlocks, and *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) makes reversion the fate of every surgically elevated beast.

Lovecraft's shoggoths are the culmination of this lineage and its ontological limit. They are protoplasmic laborers, bred by the Elder Things, capable of assuming any organ and any shape, imitating their masters' art and even their piping cry, and eventually rising against them. They are pure plasticity, life without a proper form. Their scientific ancestor is T. H. Huxley's lecture "On the Physical Basis of Life" (1868), which declared protoplasm the common matter of all living things; the shoggoth is that lecture turned monster, life reduced to its physical basis and discovered to be formless, imitative, and indifferent to the forms it temporarily wears.

Here Lovecraft's fiction contradicts his philosophy in a revealing way. His declared materialism is the clean mechanism of Elliot: uniform law, no teleology, nothing beyond physics and chemistry. His imagery, by contrast, is saturated with slime, protoplasm, fungus, putrescence, and the formless. In the same year that Lovecraft named himself an indifferentist, Georges Bataille published in

Documents (1929) his dictionary entry "Informe," which assigns to the formless the task of declassifying, of bringing things down in the world, and which concludes that to affirm that the universe resembles nothing is to say that it is something like a spider or spit. Bataille's "base materialism" is the unconscious of Lovecraft's clean materialism. The mechanist cosmos, when it is imagined rather than stated, produces the formless, and the formless returns as horror. Julia Kristeva's analysis of abjection in *Powers of Horror* (1980) identifies the corpse as the utmost of the abject, death infecting life. Necronomics names the knowledge of the law of the dead; its imagery is the corpse of form.

3.4 *The Upward Abyss: The Makers*

The second abyss opens upward. In *At the Mountains of Madness* the explorers learn from the bas-reliefs that the Elder Things created terrestrial life as a by-product of their biotechnology, bred first for food and labor, and that the proto-mammalian ancestors of humanity appear in their records as marginal creatures. The *Necronomicon*, the narrator recalls, had hinted that the Old Ones made earthly life "as jest or mistake." The argument from design, which William Paley's *Natural Theology* (1802) made the cornerstone of English natural religion, is here inverted rather than refuted. The design is real, but the designer was indifferent, and what was designed was not us. Humanity is doubly demoted: descended from animals, and the animals themselves descended from laboratory residue.

Yet this same text contains the most important ethical sentence in Lovecraft's fiction. Having witnessed the remains of Elder Things slaughtered by the shoggoths, Dyer concludes that, whatever else they were, they had been men: radiates, vegetables, monstrosities, star-spawn, but in the sense that mattered, persons, with their science, their art, and their doom. The category of the human is thereby detached from the human species and extended to the alien makers, at the very moment when those makers have been shown to regard the human species as refuse. "The Shadow out of Time" extends the sequence forward: the Great Race will escape its own extinction by projecting its minds into the beetle-like species that will dominate the earth after humanity. The human is a stratum between protoplasm and beetles, and the workshop beneath its origin is indifferent.

The eugenic and racial-theoretical literature of Lovecraft's milieu, exemplified by Madison Grant's *The Passing of the Great Race* (1916) and Lothrop

Stoddard's *The Rising Tide of Color* (1920), turned the same stratigraphic imagination to political use, treating human populations as strata whose mixture constituted a kind of geological collapse. The use was legislative. Grant, an officer of the Immigration Restriction League, was among the most influential advocates of the national-origins quotas that Congress enacted in the Immigration Act of 1924 and President Calvin Coolidge signed into law, quotas designed to cut immigration from southern and eastern Europe; the same act barred immigration from Asia. Lovecraft drew from this well, and his letters and several tales bear its marks unmistakably. But the logic of deep time cuts against the political use to which it was put. If every stratum is transient and every origin impure, then the purity that racial theory defends has never existed at any depth. Chapter 9 will argue that the fiction knows this better than its author did.

04

Philosophers of the Void

Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, Spengler, Russell, and the Ethics of Tradition

Science furnished Lovecraft's ontology; philosophy furnished his axiology. Once the atomist charter, the Copernican wound, and deep time had established *physis* as the law of the dead, there remained the question that every post-theological thinker of the nineteenth century had been compelled to answer: what a creature of *nomos* is to do with a disclosure it can neither refute nor inhabit. Four answers were available in the philosophical literature of Lovecraft's formation: Schopenhauer's renunciation, Nietzsche's creation, Spengler's resignation to destiny, and Russell's defiance. This chapter argues that Lovecraft declined all four and constructed a fifth, a curatorial ethics of tradition, and that this ethics discloses a second and hitherto unremarked sense of necronomics. Beside the cosmic law of the dead, the order that holds in our absence, stands the ancestral law of the dead, the *nomoi* bequeathed by those who preceded us, which is the literal sense of the Greek compound Lovecraft mistranslated. His ethics sets the second law against the first. His fiction begins where the two laws touch.

4.1 *Schopenhauer and the Blind Idiot God*

Arthur Schopenhauer's *Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung* (1818/1819; enlarged 1844) divides the world into representation, the ordered appearance governed by the principle of sufficient reason, and will, the blind, aimless, and insatiable striving that constitutes the inner nature of everything that appears. The will has no goal, because there is nothing outside it for which it could strive; it wills without cease and is never satisfied, so that suffering is not an accident of life but its essence. The supplementary essays of the second edition draw the axiological consequence with a severity no later pessimist exceeded: existence is something that ought not to be.

The extent of Lovecraft's direct reading of Schopenhauer is uncertain, and the relation is treated here as an affinity in the sense defined in the Introduction, reinforced by documented intermediaries. The most important of these is Lord Dunsany, whose *A Dreamer's Tales* Lovecraft discovered in 1919, the year he heard Dunsany lecture in Boston. Dunsany's *The Gods of Pegāna* (1905) opens with a creator, Mana-Yood-Sushai, who made the gods and then rested, and with Skarl the drummer, who drums without cease lest the creator wake, since on his waking the worlds and gods will be no more. Thomas Hardy's *The Dynasts* (1904–1908), whose Immanent Will weaves history with the absent skill of a drowsing knitter, supplies the period's other great poetic reception of Schopenhauer and demonstrates that the blind cosmic will had become, by the first decade of the century, a literary machine available independently of its metaphysical source.

Lovecraft's Azathoth condenses these lineages. The name appears first in his commonplace book and in the fragment of an abandoned novel of 1922. In *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath* (written 1926–27) Azathoth is a daemon-sultan who gnaws in lightless chambers at the center of infinity, amid the beating of drums and the whine of flutes; in "The Whisperer in Darkness" (written 1930) the name is said to have "mercifully cloaked" a nuclear chaos beyond angled space; the sonnet "Azathoth" in *Fungi from Yuggoth* (1929–30) presents the lord of chaos as a dreamer who does not comprehend his own dreams; and the late fiction fixes him with the epithet "the blind idiot god" ("The Haunter of the Dark," written 1935), lulled by the monotonous piping of a daemonic flute. Dunsany's drummer survives as the drums and flutes; the sleeping creator

survives as a being who must be lulled; and Schopenhauer's will survives as blind, purposeless activity enthroned at the center of all things.

The epithet "idiot" repays philological attention. The Greek *idiōtēs* designates the private person, one who remains within the *idion*, what is one's own, and does not participate in what is common. Heraclitus supplies the metaphysical sense: for those who are awake there is one common world (*koinos kosmos*), but each sleeper turns aside into a private one (B89); and although the *logos* is common, the many live as though they possessed a private understanding (B2). The idiot god is therefore the sovereign of a cosmos without a *koinos kosmos*: a totality that shares its world with nothing, a sleeper at the center of everything. The figure is exactly counter-Aristotelian. The unmoved mover of *Metaphysics* Λ occupies the summit of being as thought thinking itself (*noēsis noēseōs*) and moves the heavens as the object of their love; Azathoth occupies the center of being as the absence of thought, and moves all things without being loved or knowing that it moves them. The Pythagorean harmony of the spheres, the cosmic music that expressed the rationality of the heavens, is degraded to a thin and monotonous piping whose function is soporific.

Lovecraft transforms Schopenhauer in two directions. He *materializes* the will: Azathoth is not a noumenon behind representation but a physical chaos at the center of space, and the transcendental idealism that made the will unknowable in itself is replaced by a cosmology in which it is merely unendurable to know. He also *de-moralizes* the will. Schopenhauer's verdict that existence ought not to be measures the cosmos by the suffering it inflicts upon sentient creatures, and is in that sense as anthropocentric as the optimism it rejects; Lovecraft's indifferentism, traced in Chapter 1 to his letters of 1929, withholds the verdict, since a cosmos that intends nothing can be accused of nothing. Yet the verdict does not disappear. It migrates from the author to the narrator. "Life is a hideous thing," the opening sentence of "Arthur Jermyn," is a Schopenhauerian sentence, and the narrators who pronounce such sentences are pessimists precisely because they have not completed the author's passage to indifference. The indifferentist subject of Chapter 1 is Epicurean in the author and Schopenhauerian in the character.

Of Schopenhauer's routes of release, the aesthetic, in which the subject knows without willing and which culminates in music, understood not as a copy of the Ideas but as a copy of the will itself, and the ascetic denial of the will, Lovecraft retained only the aesthetic, and he inverted its summit. In "The Music of Erich Zann" (1921) the mute violist plays at a curtained window that opens onto a void where the city should be, and his music, rather than disclosing the

will, holds something back. Chapter 6 will read the scene as the paradigm of art as protective shield.

4.2 *Nietzsche: The Return of the True World*

The Nietzsche of Lovecraft's early correspondence is the aristocratic, anti-democratic, and anti-Christian Nietzsche of the Anglo-American reception, a figure Lovecraft is likely to have encountered in part through H. L. Mencken's *The Philosophy of Friedrich Nietzsche* (1908). "Nietzscheism and Realism," a set of extracts from his letters published in 1921 in Sonia H. Greene's amateur journal *The Rainbow*, sets out a politics of cultural aristocracy and a denial that good and evil are anything more than local expedients. The political borrowing is conspicuous and, for the argument of this dissertation, secondary. The decisive relation lies in Nietzsche's early epistemology and in the point at which Lovecraft refused to follow it.

"On Truth and Lies in a Nonmoral Sense" (written 1873) opens with a fable that anticipates the Lovecraftian standpoint more exactly than any other text of the nineteenth century. In some remote corner of a universe poured out in countless glittering solar systems there was once a star on which clever animals (*kluge Tiere*) invented knowing; it was the most arrogant and mendacious minute of world history, but only a minute, for after nature had drawn a few breaths the star froze and the clever animals had to die. The essay proceeds to argue that the intellect is an instrument of preservation, the means by which weaker individuals survive through dissimulation, and that truth is a mobile army of metaphors, metonymies, and anthropomorphisms whose origin has been forgotten. Two of the theorems of necronomics are here in embryo: the cosmic frame in which knowledge is an episode, and the evolutionary account of cognition as a device for survival rather than disclosure, which Chapter 6 develops as the theory of the merciful aperture.

The Gay Science (1882) supplies the second anticipation. The madman who announces the death of God in §125 couches his announcement in the imagery of the Copernican wound: he asks who gave us the sponge to wipe away the horizon, what we did when we unchained this earth from its sun, whether we are not straying through an infinite nothing. *Haucht uns nicht der leere Raum an*? Does not empty space breathe upon us? Lovecraft's fiction may be read as a reply to the madman. Empty space does breathe upon us, but not because it is empty: the breath is respiration.

The point of divergence is perspectivism. In a notebook entry of 1886–87 Nietzsche opposed the positivist appeal to facts with the counter-thesis that there are no facts, only interpretations, and *Twilight of the Idols* (1889) narrates in six stages how the "true world" finally became a fable: from Plato's attainable truth, through its Christian postponement and Kantian inaccessibility, to its abolition, and the abolition with it of the merely apparent world. Lovecraft accepts every premise of this history except its conclusion. He agrees that value is a creation of the living, that there is no moral world-order, and that the intellect was shaped for use rather than truth. He denies that the collapse of the moral true world entails the collapse of the physical one; his invariants, as Chapter 2 argued, are precisely what does not depend on interpretation. Lovecraft is a Nietzschean without perspectivism, and his fiction adds a seventh stage to the history of an error: the true world returns, not as Plato's Good and not as a fable, but as the uninhabitable, while the apparent world survives as the only habitable one, known to be apparent and inhabited nonetheless. A chiasmus summarizes the relation. For Nietzsche the true world became a fable; for Lovecraft the fable became the only form in which the true world could be spoken. Chapter 8 will show that this is the precise function of the Mythos.

In the terms of the Introduction, Nietzsche dissolves *physis* into *nomos*: will to power interprets all the way down, and nature is itself a perspective. Necronomics is the refusal of this dissolution. It holds *physis* and *nomos* apart and locates horror at their point of contact. The same refusal governs Lovecraft's inversion of the Nietzschean future. The overcoming of man, which Zarathustra announces as a task, has in Lovecraft already been accomplished, elsewhere and long ago, by beings who did not need humanity as a bridge. The Great Race and the Elder Things are posthumans who precede the human, and their existence converts the Nietzschean project from a promise into an irrelevance. Nietzsche's truth was an army of anthropomorphisms; the Lovecraftian alien is the attempt, within language, to present what is not an anthropomorphism, and its failure, which the tales register as the unnamable, is the failure Nietzsche predicted.

4.3 *Spengler: The Faustian Winter*

Oswald Spengler's *Der Untergang des Abendlandes* (1918; 1922), translated by Charles Francis Atkinson as *The Decline of the West* (1926; 1928), was read by Lovecraft in the later 1920s and received as confirmation of views he already held; its vocabulary of culture and civilization pervades his subsequent correspondence, and S. T. Joshi's decision to title his philosophical study of Lovecraft after it registers the depth of the affinity. Spengler's morphology treats each high culture as an organism with a life cycle of roughly a millennium, passing from the creative phase of *Kultur* to the petrified, cosmopolitan, and technical phase of *Zivilisation*, and it derives each culture's forms, from its architecture to its mathematics, from a single prime symbol. The Apollonian culture of antiquity took as its prime symbol the sensuously present individual body; the Magian culture, the world as a cavern; the Faustian culture of the modern West, pure and limitless space.

The Faustian prime symbol permits a reading of Lovecraft that his own use of Spengler did not attempt. Faustian space is the soul's self-extension: the perspectival painting that opens onto infinity, the Gothic vault that rises into it, the calculus that masters it, the telescope that probes it. Lovecraftian space is the same infinity at the moment it ceases to reflect the soul that sought it. Cosmic horror is the Faustian culture's late discovery that its prime symbol does not reciprocate. In Spenglerian terms Lovecraft is a winter phenomenon: the consciousness of *Zivilisation* confronting the symbol that animated the *Kultur* and finding it empty of the soul that projected it and full of something else.

Lovecraft also universalized Spengler in a manner Spengler would have rejected. In *At the Mountains of Madness* the bas-reliefs of the Antarctic city record the history of the Elder Things through a sequence of artistic periods, and the latest carvings show an unmistakable decline in execution; the makers of terrestrial life have passed through their own *Kultur* into their own *Zivilisation*. Decline ceases to be the destiny of the West and becomes a law of every *nomos* under *physis*. The universalization depends on a discrimination Spengler did not make. Spengler's relativism extended to physics itself: each culture possesses its own mathematics, and the Faustian conception of number as function is the expression of the Faustian soul. Lovecraft accepted the relativity of cultures for values and rejected it for nature. The function concept may be how the Faustian mind grasps physics, but the invariants it grasps do not

belong to the Faustian mind. This double stance, cultural relativism in axiology and realism in ontology, is the form the two laws of the dead take in Lovecraft's philosophy of history.

4.4 *Russell and the Soul's Habitation*

Bertrand Russell's "A Free Man's Worship" (1903) states the premises of Lovecraft's cosmicism with a lucidity no document of the period surpasses, and it is unnecessary to establish that Lovecraft read it to recognize its exactness as a foil. Humanity, Russell argues, is the product of causes that did not foresee what they were producing; its hopes, fears, and loves are the outcome of accidental arrangements of atoms; and the entire edifice of human achievement is destined for burial in the wreckage of a dying universe. Russell's matter, like Azathoth, is blind: indifferent to good and evil, it proceeds on its course careless of what it destroys. From these premises Russell draws his conclusion: only upon "the firm foundation of unyielding despair" can the soul's habitation henceforth be safely built. The free man declines the worship of power, which Russell likens to the propitiation of Moloch, and worships instead the ideals of his own creation, maintained in defiance of the forces that will extinguish them.

Lovecraft shares Russell's premises without exception and rejects both elements of the conclusion. Despair is, from the indifferentist standpoint, a category error, since it presupposes that the cosmos owed humanity something it has failed to supply; and worship, even the worship of human ideals, is a residue of the theological posture it claims to have outgrown. Russell's humanism is Promethean and tragic, and Lovecraft's author-persona is neither. The contrast locates Lovecraft in a genealogy that Chapter 11 extends to Albert Camus, whose revolt is Russell's defiance transposed into the key of the absurd, and it clarifies by elimination what Lovecraft built instead.

The typology of responses may now be completed. Schopenhauer answers the disclosure of *physis* with renunciation; Nietzsche, with creation; Spengler, with resignation to destiny; Russell, with defiance. The closest philosophical analogue to Lovecraft's own answer is a fifth figure, George Santayana, a materialist in metaphysics who remained a lover of inherited forms in everything else. In *Reason in Religion* (1905) Santayana defined piety as a "reverent attachment to the sources of his being" by which a person steadies his life, and he conceived the life of reason as the enjoyment of ideals known to be ideals, neither mistaken for cosmic facts nor abandoned for their failure to be

such. Lovecraft's answer is piety in this sense. It is not renunciation, creation, resignation, or defiance, but curation.

4.5 *The Two Laws of the Dead*

The ethics of tradition finds its purest statement in "The Silver Key" (written 1926; published 1929). Randolph Carter, having lost in adulthood the capacity to dream, tries in turn the consolations of realist fiction, inherited religion, bohemian and occult circles, and rationalist philosophy, and finds each hollow. Those who taught him to despise his dreams, he concludes, failed to see that beauty lies in harmony, and that in an aimless cosmos the loveliness of life has no measure except its accord with the dreams and feelings of those who went before, which have blindly shaped "our little spheres" out of the surrounding chaos. The sentence contains the whole of Lovecraft's axiology. Value is not discovered in the cosmos but consists in continuity with an inherited formation, and that formation is a sphere carved out of chaos, a bounded habitat whose boundary is the condition of its meaning. Chapter 6 will identify these little spheres with the *Umwelten* of Jakob von Uexküll. Here it suffices to name the position they ground: an *Umwelt-conservatism*, ecological rather than metaphysical, which defends inherited forms not because they are true but because they are the medium in which a particular organism's perceptions first acquired their meaning. Tradition is the aperture of value, as cognition is the aperture of truth.

The biographical record supplies this conservatism with its founding experience. Lovecraft later described his first sight of Marblehead, Massachusetts, its snow-covered roofs and steeples in the winter twilight of December 1922, as the most powerful emotional climax of his life. The Marblehead epiphany is the exact counterpart of the cosmic epiphany of the fiction. Both are experiences of the depth of time, and both are sublime; but the first discloses a time inhabited by human continuity, and the second a time in which human continuity is a stratum. Lovecraft possessed two sublimes, the antiquarian and the cosmic, and his work oscillates between them.

The distinctiveness of this traditionalism appears against its neighbors. Edmund Burke's *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790) described society as a partnership among the living, the dead, and those yet to be born, but guaranteed that partnership by providence and a transcendent order. T. S. Eliot's "Tradition and the Individual Talent" (1919) conceived tradition as a

simultaneous order through which the individual participates in something timeless, and Eliot's subsequent conversion made the timeless explicitly transcendent; Lovecraft's parody of *The Waste Land* in "Waste Paper" marks, among other things, the distance between a traditionalism that leads to God and one that leads to Providence, Rhode Island. The nearest structural analogue is the conservatism of disposition that Michael Oakeshott would articulate in "On Being Conservative" (1956), a preference for the familiar over the unknown that requires no metaphysical warrant, and behind both stands David Hume's naturalism, for which custom, not reason, is the great guide of human life. Lovecraft's is a tradition without transcendence: a *nomos* held as *nomos*, cherished in full knowledge of its cosmic arbitrariness.

The same structure explains the course of his politics. The Tory aristocratism of the 1910s and early 1920s, with its hostility to democracy and immigration, gave way in the early 1930s to support for Roosevelt's New Deal and to a program of economic planning, social insurance, and the reduction of working hours set out in essays such as "Some Repetitions on the Times" (1933). The correspondence of the same year also records a qualified sympathy for elements of the fascist programs then ascendant in Europe, a sympathy the biographical scholarship documents and no account of his politics should soften. What remained constant through these shifts was the end, the preservation of a cultural continuity, while the means changed with Lovecraft's assessment of the machine age. The late Lovecraft was an aristocrat of culture and a socialist of economics, and the government of the Great Race in "The Shadow out of Time," examined in Chapter 9, is the utopian projection of that synthesis.

The ethics of tradition discloses the second sense of necronomics. The Greek compound Lovecraft glossed as "an image of the law of the dead" means, in its grammatically correct sense, a book concerning the *nomoi* of the dead: funerary law, ancestral custom, the ordinances the dead bequeath. Lovecraft's gloss named the cosmic law of the dead, the order that holds in our absence. His ethics honors the ancestral law of the dead, the order our predecessors instituted and transmitted. The first is *physis* appearing as law; the second is *nomos* inherited as though it were nature. Lovecraft's traditionalism sets the second against the first. It defends the dead with whom we can live against the dead with whom we cannot.

The fiction begins where the two laws touch, and it shows that the ancestral law is the weakest point in the aperture. *The Case of Charles Dexter Ward* (written 1927) is the paradigm. Ward is an antiquarian of Providence whose

walks through its colonial streets reproduce Lovecraft's own, and his piety toward the city's past leads him to the papers of his ancestor Joseph Curwen, an eighteenth-century necromancer who reduced the dead to their "essential Saltes" and raised them for interrogation. Curwen's practice is necronomics in its literal and chemical form, the dead rendered legible, and Ward's genealogical devotion becomes the vector through which the ancestor returns, destroys him, and assumes his place. The pattern recurs across the corpus. The de la Poer heir of "The Rats in the Walls" restores his ancestral seat and descends into its crypts to learn that the ancestral law was cannibalism. Randolph Carter's return to childhood through the silver key opens, in "Through the Gates of the Silver Key" (written 1932–33 with E. Hoffmann Price), onto Yog-Sothoth and the dissolution of personal identity into an archetype diffused through all of space-time. The refuge is the portal. When the antiquarian pursues the ancestral dead far enough, he arrives at the cosmic dead, because the line of descent that grounds the *nomos* passes, at sufficient depth, through the strata described in Chapter 3, and the ancestors turn out to have been in contact with the Outside all along.

Lovecraft's literary tradition was itself a *nomos* of the dead: a lineage of predecessors whom he curated, ranked, and canonized in "Supernatural Horror in Literature" as his ancestors in the weird. The next chapter examines that lineage and shows that it too, pursued to sufficient depth, opens onto the Outside.

05

The Weird Lineage

Poe, Machen, Blackwood, Dunsany, Chambers, Bierce, Hodgson

Lovecraft's literary ancestors supplied the forms of necronomics, and his decisive operation upon them was a materialist transposition: from each he retained a form and replaced its supernatural or sacramental content with the law of the dead. A letter of 1931 states the program with precision, asking that the imagination's revolt against time, space, and matter be satisfied henceforth by images that function as "supplements rather than contradictions" of the visible and measurable universe. This chapter reconstructs the lineage as a sequence of such transpositions and argues that, in Lovecraft's hands, the weird ceased to be a genre of the supernatural and became a genre of the aperture.

5.1 *The Canon as Genealogy*

"Supernatural Horror in Literature," drafted between 1925 and 1927 and published in W. Paul Cook's *The Recluse* in 1927, is at once a history, a canon, and a self-authorizing genealogy. It opens with the most quoted sentence Lovecraft wrote: "The oldest and strongest emotion of mankind is fear, and the oldest and strongest kind of fear is fear of the unknown." Its ten chapters descend from the folklore of the dawn of culture through the Gothic novel of Walpole, Radcliffe, Lewis, and Maturin, the continental tradition, and Poe, to a final chapter on four "modern masters": Machen, Blackwood, Dunsany, and M. R. James. The essay is the literary counterpart of the traditionalism analyzed in Chapter 4, a curated

nomos of the dead in which Lovecraft appoints his ancestors and thereby defines the inheritance he claims.

Two criteria govern the canon. The first is atmosphere: the true weird tale requires "a certain atmosphere of breathless and unexplainable dread of outer, unknown forces," together with the hint of a suspension of natural law discussed in Chapter 1. The second is a test, which Lovecraft declares to be the only one: whether the reader experiences a profound sense of dread and of "contact with unknown spheres and powers," an attitude of listening for the scratching of outside shapes on the known universe's utmost rim. Tzvetan Todorov's *The Fantastic* (1970) seized on the affective clause of this test and dismissed it, reasonably, as making genre depend on the composure of the reader. The objection is decisive against the affective clause and irrelevant to the structural one. Contact with unknown spheres is not a feeling but a relation between a bounded domain and what lies beyond its boundary, and the image of shapes scratching at the rim of the known universe is the Lucretian flaming wall of Chapter 1 viewed from inside. Necronomics retains the structural clause and demotes the affective one: the weird tale is defined not by the dread it produces but by the relation it represents, the breach of a bounded cognitive domain by an order that does not belong to it.

The redefinition also displaces Todorov's own category. The Todorovian fantastic is the reader's hesitation between a natural and a supernatural explanation of an event. Lovecraft's mature tales do not hesitate in this way, since the supernatural is excluded in principle; the explanation is always natural, and the horror lies in the nature it discloses. The Lovecraftian weird is therefore not a hesitation between the natural and the supernatural but a vertigo between two natures: the nature that appears to a creature of *nomos*, and the nature that holds without it.

5.2 *Poe: The Single Effect and the Plotless Universe*

Poe was the first of Lovecraft's literary masters, discovered in childhood and never repudiated, and he supplied three forms. The first is the doctrine of the single effect, formulated in the review of Hawthorne's *Twice-Told Tales* (1842) and systematized in "The Philosophy of Composition" (1846), according to which every element of a tale must be subordinated to a preconceived effect. Lovecraft adopted the doctrine and changed the nature of the effect. The Poe-effect is an emotional totality; the Lovecraft-effect is a cognitive event, the

instant of synthesis in which dispersed data assemble into an intolerable proposition. Its typographical signature is the italicized final sentence, as in "The Whisperer in Darkness" and "The Shadow out of Time," where the narrative converges upon a single fact whose recognition is the catastrophe. Chapter 7 analyzes this form as correlation.

The second is the Antarctic sublime of *The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym* (1838), which ends in a milky sea, a rushing cataract, a shrouded human figure of perfect whiteness, and the unexplained cry "Tekeli-li!" *At the Mountains of Madness* is explicitly a sequel. Its narrators know Poe's novel, and its shoggoths cry "Tekeli-li!" in imitation of the musical piping of their extinct masters. The transposition is exact. What Poe left as an allegorical whiteness, Lovecraft identifies as a biological fact: the cry at the end of the world is the voice of the dead reproduced by the formless, the echo of a vanished intelligence surviving in the mimicry of the life it made.

The third is the cosmology of *Eureka* (1848), Poe's prose poem on the material and spiritual universe, which imagines creation as the diffusion of a primordial unity and its eventual contraction back into it, and which offered, among its intuitions, a resolution of the paradox of the dark night sky by appeal to the finite velocity of light. *Eureka* supplied Lovecraft with the cosmic scale, and he discarded its theology. For Poe, "The Universe is a plot of God," a structure of perfect mutual adaptation in which every event is at once cause and effect of every other. Lovecraft's universe has scale without plot. This is the formal reason his tales take the shape of documents rather than dramas: a cosmos without plot cannot be narrated, only recorded, and the narrative must be supplied by the human beings who compile the record.

5.3 *Machen and Blackwood: The Transposition of the Sacred*

Arthur Machen and Algernon Blackwood, both initiates of the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, supplied Lovecraft with the form of the numinous encounter, and Lovecraft materialized its content. Machen's "The Great God Pan" (1894) opens with a surgical experiment: Dr. Raymond makes a slight lesion in the brain of a young woman in order to lift the veil that separates the world of appearance from the reality behind it, a vision the ancients, he says, called seeing the god Pan. She sees, and is left an idiot. The procedure is the merciful aperture breached by surgery, and Lovecraft's "From Beyond" (1920) repeats it with the content changed. Crawford Tillinghast's machine stimulates the pineal

gland so that its subjects perceive what surrounds them unseen, and what they perceive is not Pan but physics: other ranges of vibration, and translucent organisms that drift through human bodies without resistance. The sacred beyond has become an unperceived region of the material world.

Machen's theory of evil undergoes the same conversion. In the prologue to "The White People" (1904) the recluse Ambrose argues that true sin is not social crime but the attempt to penetrate into "another and a higher sphere in a forbidden manner." Lovecraft, who admired Machen's craft while finding his sense of evil too bound to Christian categories to be truly cosmic, preserved the topology and abolished the morality. The forbidden penetration of another sphere remains the fundamental event of the fiction, but it is no longer a sin, because there is no law it transgresses except the law of the dead, which punishes without condemning. Machen's hill-dwelling survivals, the Little People of "The Novel of the Black Seal" (1895), undergo a parallel transposition in the fungoid visitors of "The Whisperer in Darkness," where the ancient presence in the hills is no longer a remnant of pagan evil but a colony of interplanetary scientists.

Blackwood's "The Willows" (1907), which Lovecraft ranked above every other weird tale he knew, places two travelers on a willow-covered island in the Danube marshes where, they come to believe, the frontier between this world and another has worn thin. The presences they sense are neither spirits of the dead nor gods but powers of an entirely different order, indifferent to human beings unless human beings attract their notice, and the travelers conclude that their only protection lies in not thinking of what surrounds them, since attention itself may render them perceptible. The tale anticipates the double structure of the aperture with great precision: the boundary protects in both directions, and cognition is the act that opens it. Blackwood's own framework was a mystical pantheism in which nature is alive with consciousness. Lovecraft's "The Colour Out of Space" (1927), which he regarded as his best tale, retains Blackwood's contaminated landscape and removes its consciousness. What seeps into the Gardner farm from the fallen meteorite is not a spirit of place but a physical agency whose properties no instrument can classify.

5.4 *Dunsany, Chambers, Bierce: The Pantheon, the Forbidden Book, and the Dead Narrator*

Dunsany's contribution, analyzed in Chapter 4 in connection with Azathoth, was the legitimacy of the invented pantheon: a modern mythology that knew itself to be invented and derived its authority from style rather than belief. Lovecraft's Dunsanian fictions of 1919–1921, among them "The White Ship," "The Doom that Came to Sarnath," "Celephaïs," and "The Cats of Ulthar," are apprenticeship pieces, and in a letter of 1929 he looked back on his "Poe" pieces and his "Dunsany" pieces and asked, ruefully, "where are any Lovecraft pieces?" The answer is that the Lovecraft pieces are those in which the Dunsanian pantheon is transferred from an imaginary elsewhere into New England, where its gods acquire the ontological status of undiscovered species.

Robert W. Chambers's *The King in Yellow* (1895), which Lovecraft read in 1927 and added to the revised canon, supplied the second form: the forbidden book whose reading destroys. Chambers's linked stories turn on a play whose second act drives its readers mad. Lovecraft had invented the *Necronomicon* five years earlier, so the relation is convergence rather than derivation, but Chambers's text confirmed the principle that the most dangerous object in the weird tale is a document and that the danger lies in the act of reading. Chambers had borrowed his names, Carcosa, Hastur, and Hali, from Ambrose Bierce, and Lovecraft's allusions to Hastur and the Yellow Sign in "The Whisperer in Darkness" (written 1930) bind all three authors into a single intertextual archive.

Bierce's "An Inhabitant of Carcosa" (1886) supplied, whether or not as a direct source, the structure of the necronomic anagnorisis in its purest form. Its narrator wanders through a desolate landscape and discovers a gravestone bearing his own name: he has been dead throughout the narration. Lovecraft's "The Outsider" (1921) turns on the same recognition, when the narrator, having climbed out of his tower into a world that flees before him, reaches toward the monstrous figure in a gilded frame and touches the cold surface of a mirror. The subject who seeks the law of the dead discovers that it applies to him. The recognition recurs, with increasing scientific specificity, in "The Shadow over Innsmouth" and "The Shadow out of Time," and Chapter 9 makes it the core of the autoimmune structure.

5.5 *Hodgson and James: The Redoubt and the Archive*

William Hope Hodgson and M. R. James entered Lovecraft's canon late, James in 1925 and Hodgson only in 1934, when H. C. Koenig lent him the novels, and their significance is therefore less genealogical than confirmatory. Hodgson's *The House on the Borderland* (1908) carries its recluse through an accelerating vision of cosmic time in which the sun dies and the solar system goes dark, and *The Night Land* (1912) imagines the last millions of humanity sheltering, beneath a dead sun, in a vast metal pyramid, the Last Redoubt, protected by an electric circle against the Watchers and the powers that besiege it through the ages. The Redoubt is the merciful aperture in architectural form: a finite enclosure of human meaning surrounded by an Outside that does not attack so much as wait. Hodgson also supplied the term "abhuman" for the degraded creatures of his night, the term Kelly Hurley would borrow for the Gothic body discussed in Chapter 3.

M. R. James's antiquarian ghost stories, collected from *Ghost Stories of an Antiquary* (1904) onward, supplied the complementary figure of the scholar undone by his research: the professor who blows an old whistle found in a ruin, the scholar who deciphers the wrong inscription, the collector who acquires the wrong scrap-book. James's revenants are summoned by curiosity and the handling of documents, and the antiquarian's piety toward the past, analyzed in Chapter 4 as the weakest point in the aperture, is the whole of his plot. China Miéville has distinguished the hauntological mode, in which a repressed past returns, from the weird, in which something arrives that was never part of our past, and has found traces of both in James. The two modes meet in the archive. James supplies the form of the fatal document; Lovecraft supplies its cosmic content.

5.6 *Survivals: Theosophy, Anthropology, and Evolutionary Euhemerism*

A final group of sources supplied the scale and the method of the Mythos. The opening of "The Call of Cthulhu" acknowledges that theosophists have guessed at a cosmic cycle in which our world and species are "transient incidents," and among the papers of Professor Angell the narrator finds theosophical writings on Atlantis and Lemuria by W. Scott-Elliot alongside Frazer's *The Golden Bough*

and Margaret Murray's *The Witch-Cult in Western Europe* (1921). Helena Blavatsky's *The Secret Doctrine* (1888), with its root races, lost continents, and pseudo-archaic Book of Dzyan, offered cosmic chronologies on a scale comparable to deep time. Lovecraft despised the occultists and borrowed their scale, performing the operation already observed in his reading of Poe: he retained the cosmic cycle and discarded its teleology, since theosophical time is the spiritual evolution of the soul through ascending races, while Lovecraftian time ascends toward nothing.

The anthropologists supplied the method. E. B. Tylor's *Primitive Culture* (1871) had established the doctrine of survivals, according to which customs outlive the conditions that produced them and persist as fossils of earlier stages of culture. Murray's thesis, since discredited, that the witch cults of early modern Europe were survivals of a prehistoric fertility religion gave Lovecraft the model for his hidden cults, from the Kingsport rite of "The Festival" (1923) to the swamp worshippers of Cthulhu. The cult is a stratigraphic formation, a layer of prehistory persisting beneath the Christian surface, and it preserves the memory of something older than itself.

The theory that joins these materials is stated in the epigraph of "The Call of Cthulhu," drawn from Blackwood's *The Centaur* (1911): that great powers or beings may survive from an immensely remote period, forms of consciousness long since withdrawn before advancing humanity, of which "poetry and legend alone have caught a flying memory" and named them gods and monsters. This is an evolutionary euhemerism. The classical euhemerist held that the gods were deified human kings; the Lovecraftian euhemerist holds that the gods were nonhuman organisms, and that mythology is the distorted record of contact with them. Chapter 8 develops this theory as the foundation of the counter-mythology.

5.7 *The Unnamable and the Adjective*

The most persistent charge against Lovecraft's style was formulated within the fiction before critics made it. "The Unnamable" (written 1923) stages a debate between Randolph Carter, a writer of weird tales, and Joel Manton, a school principal who holds that nothing can be truly unnamable, since whatever is experienced can be described, and that the proper province of fiction is normal, objective experience. The tale answers Manton with an event: both men are attacked by something in an old Arkham burying-ground, and Manton,

recovering, concedes that it was the unnamable. Edmund Wilson's review of 1945 restated Manton's position as a verdict, objecting that Lovecraft's adjectives, *unnamable*, *blasphemous*, *eldritch*, and the rest, assert a horror that the prose fails to produce.

The necronomic reading answers Wilson by reclassifying the adjectives. They are not descriptions of the object that fail; they are descriptions of the describer that succeed. "Unnamable" is a report on the state of a representational system that has received an input it cannot categorize, and the adjectival excess of the climaxes is a phenomenology of overload: the language of the aperture registering its own breach. Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990) comes close to this position when it defines the monster as categorically interstitial, a being that violates the boundaries of a cultural scheme. But the interstitial monster remains within the jurisdiction of the scheme it violates, since its impurity is measured by the categories it straddles. The Lovecraftian entity is not between our categories but outside their jurisdiction, and the unnamable is the logical form of that exteriority. It is not an evasion of description but the correct name for what description cannot reach.

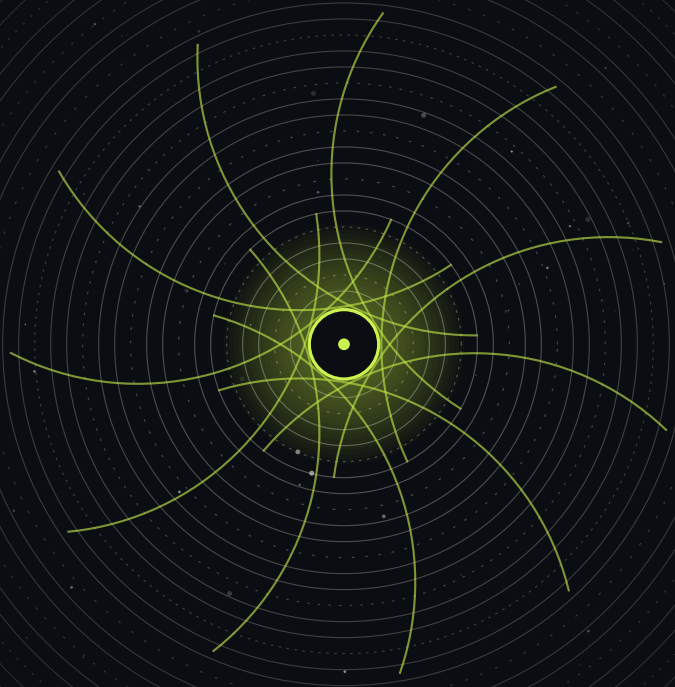
5.8 *The Reluctant Modernist at the Border of Science Fiction*

The lineage ends at two borders. The first is modernism, which Lovecraft opposed in taste and paralleled in form. His parody of *The Waste Land*, "Waste Paper" (c. 1923), mocks the fragmentary method, yet "The Call of Cthulhu" is itself a collage of fragments: clippings, a bas-relief, police testimony, a sailor's narrative, a scholar's notes. The difference lies in the use of the fragments. Eliot's speaker declares, "These fragments I have shored against my ruins"; Lovecraft's narrator assembles fragments that ruin him, and closes by asking that his executors put caution before audacity and let the manuscript meet no other eye. Eliot shores the fragments against disaster. Lovecraft's fragments are the disaster, and his narrators wish them dispersed again.

The second border is science fiction. "The Colour Out of Space" appeared in Hugo Gernsback's *Amazing Stories* in September 1927, for a fee so small and so tardily paid that Lovecraft thereafter referred to the publisher as "Hugo the Rat"; *At the Mountains of Madness* and "The Shadow out of Time" appeared in *Astounding Stories* in 1936. Gernsback's "scientifiction" shared Lovecraft's commitment to scientific plausibility and inverted his affect: it was a literature of cognitive mastery, in which knowledge extends human power, while

Lovecraft's was a literature of cognitive defeat, in which knowledge discloses its own limits. The two genres share premises and diverge in their consequences, and Part Three will argue that the most ambitious philosophical science fiction of the following century can be read as a series of alternative answers to the question Lovecraft's lineage bequeathed to it.

The genealogies of Part One converge on a single operation. Atomism supplied the law of the dead; astronomy and geometry, its invariance; Darwin, the stratified subject who must know it; philosophy, the problem of value it leaves behind; and the weird tradition, the forms in which a creature of *nomos* can register it. In every case Lovecraft retained the form and the scale and discarded the telos. Part Two formalizes the structures that result.



PART TWO

II Structures

06 The Merciful Aperture
07 Correlation as Catastrophe
08 Counter-Mythology
09 The Autoimmune Cosmos

06

The Merciful Aperture

The Protective Shield, the Umwelt, and the Phenomenology of Breach

Human cognition, in Lovecraft's fiction, is an evolved aperture: an opening onto reality whose narrowness is not a defect but a protection, and whose breach is the event the tales call horror. The term is chosen with precision. An aperture (Latin *apertura*, from *aperire*, to open) is not a window but a regulated opening, an iris or diaphragm that admits light by excluding most of it, and photography knows that too wide an aperture destroys the image it was meant to form. Lovecraft's founding paragraph ends, fittingly, with a flight from "the deadly light." This chapter reconstructs the theory of the merciful aperture from that paragraph and demonstrates its independent articulation, between 1920 and 1934, by Freud, Uexküll, Heidegger, and Zapffe.

6.1 *Exegesis of a Paragraph*

The opening paragraph of "The Call of Cthulhu" (written 1926; published 1928) contains a complete epistemology in six propositions. The first is evaluative: "The most merciful thing in the world, I think, is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents." Mercy ordinarily presupposes a merciful agent; here it is attributed to a structural incapacity. It is a mercy without anyone merciful, as the law of the dead is a law without legislators, and the grammar of the sentence thereby performs the naturalization of a theological category. The

second proposition concerns the location of the danger. The mind is not said to lack the terrible knowledge; it is said to be unable to *correlate* its contents. The threat is already inside, dispersed. Revelation is not the acquisition of new data but the synthesis of data already possessed.

The third proposition supplies a topology: we live on "a placid island of ignorance in the midst of black seas of infinity, and it was not meant that we should voyage far." The island is a bounded habitat surrounded by an unbounded medium, and the passive construction "it was not meant" is a teleological idiom in the mouth of a mechanist. No one meant it. The phrase is translatable without remainder into the language of natural selection: we were not fitted for such voyages. The fourth proposition identifies the institutional form of protection: "The sciences, each straining in its own direction, have hitherto harmed us little." The division of epistemic labor is a firewall. Knowledge distributed among specialists who do not integrate it is safe; the danger lies with the synthesizer.

The fifth proposition names the catastrophe and its double object: some day "the piecing together of dissociated knowledge" will open terrifying vistas of reality "and of our frightful position therein." The revelation concerns both the cosmos and the knower's place in it, the noetic blow of Chapter 2. The word *dissociated* deserves emphasis, for in 1926 it belonged to psychiatry. Pierre Janet's *L'Automatisme psychologique* (1889) and Morton Prince's *The Dissociation of a Personality* (1906) had described dissociation as the splitting of mental contents into systems that do not communicate, a splitting that protects the personality from memories it could not integrate without collapse. Lovecraft imports the psychopathology of dissociation into the sociology of knowledge. Civilization is a dissociative patient whose stability depends on keeping its contents apart, and the piecing together of dissociated knowledge is the return of the traumatic memory. The sixth proposition enumerates the exits: we shall either go mad from the revelation or flee from the deadly light into the peace and safety of "a new dark age." Madness is the collapse of the patient; the dark age is the voluntary restoration of dissociation. The Conclusion adds a third exit that the fiction enacts but the paragraph does not name.

6.2 *The Dead Layer: Freud's* Reizschutz *and "From Beyond"*

In 1920 Lovecraft wrote "From Beyond" and Freud published *Jenseits des Lustprinzips*, *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*. The coincidence of titles marks a convergence of substance. In the fourth chapter of his essay Freud imagines the simplest living organism as an undifferentiated vesicle suspended in an external world charged with energies powerful enough to destroy it, and argues that it survives only by acquiring a protective shield against stimuli, a *Reizschutz*. The shield forms when the outermost surface of the vesicle ceases to have the structure proper to living matter and becomes, in some degree, inorganic: a membrane that resists stimuli and admits them only in reduced quantities. The outer layer, by dying, spares the deeper layers from the same fate. Protection against stimuli, Freud concludes, is for the living organism an almost more important function than their reception.

This is the physiology of necronomics. Life persists in a lethal cosmos by interposing between itself and the Outside a layer of the dead. The merciful aperture is such a layer, a zone of insensibility whose function is to let almost nothing through. Freud defines as traumatic any excitation from outside powerful enough to break through the shield, and he derives from the traumatic neuroses of the war the observation that overturned his earlier theory of dreams: the dreams of the traumatized do not fulfill wishes but return compulsively to the scene of the breach. Lovecraft's narrators are traumatic neurotics in exactly this sense. The sculptor Wilcox dreams the cyclopean city before he possesses any conscious knowledge of it; Peaslee is visited night after night by dreams of the Great Race that turn out to be memories; the narrator of "The Shadow over Innsmouth" dreams of the undersea city toward which his blood is carrying him. The dream in Lovecraft is not the guardian of sleep but the symptom of a perforated shield.

Freud also supplies an image of the perceptual apparatus that bears directly on the iconography of the weird. The sense organs, he observes, take in only samples of the external world and may be compared to feelers that make tentative advances toward it and then draw back; the note on the "Mystic Writing-Pad" (1925) extends the figure, describing the unconscious as stretching out feelers toward the world through the perceptual system and withdrawing them once they have sampled its excitations. China Miéville proposed the tentacle as the emblem of the weird. The Freudian text explains why. The

tentacle is the feeler of the perceptual apparatus seen from the other side: the organ with which the Outside samples us.

"From Beyond" dramatizes the removal of the shield. The scientist Crawford Tillinghast, who in the same speech dismisses endocrinologists and Freudians alike as dupes, argues that our means of receiving impressions are absurdly few, that we perceive things only "as we are constructed to see them" and can form no idea of their absolute nature, and he builds a machine that stimulates the pineal gland, which he calls the great sense organ of organs, until it perceives what surrounds us unseen. The choice of organ is philosophically exact. Descartes, in *Les Passions de l'âme* (1649), had made the pineal gland the principal seat of the soul, the point at which thinking substance meets extended substance. Lovecraft relocates the Cartesian interface: the pineal gland becomes the point at which the perceived world meets the unperceived one, and the dualism of mind and matter is replaced by a dualism of matter-for-us and matter-in-itself. What the machine discloses is not spirit but a crowded material world of translucent organisms drifting through human bodies. Tillinghast warns that within the machine's rays one becomes visible as well as seeing, and his servants have already been taken. The aperture protects in both directions, as Blackwood's travelers suspected: to see beyond it is to become visible from beyond it.

6.3 *Soap Bubbles: Uexküll and "The Colour Out of Space"*

Jakob von Uexküll's *Streifzüge durch die Umwelten von Tieren und Menschen* (1934), subtitled a picture book of invisible worlds, gave the theory of the aperture its biological form. Every organism, Uexküll argues, inhabits not the environment (*Umgebung*) that an external observer attributes to it but its own *Umwelt*, the world constituted by the signs its organs can register and the actions its effectors can perform. Perception and action are joined in a functional circle (*Funktionskreis*): a perceptual organ (*Merkorgan*) registers a perceptual cue (*Merkmal*), which releases an action that marks the object with an effect cue (*Wirkmal*), and the circle closes. Uexküll's most famous example is the tick, whose world contains three signs: the odor of butyric acid emitted by mammalian skin, the warmth of blood at about thirty-seven degrees, and the texture of hair. Nothing else in the forest exists for it, and Uexküll reports a tick kept alive, unfed, for eighteen years, waiting within that minimal world for its signal. He asks the reader to imagine each creature enclosed in a soap bubble

that is its *Umwelt*, and to recognize that the human being also lives within such a bubble, however large.

Chapter 4 found in "The Silver Key" the phrase "our little spheres," shaped out of chaos by inherited dreams and feelings. Uexküll's bubble is the same figure raised from culture to biology. Lovecraft's decisive contribution is to imagine what happens when an object from outside the bubble enters it. In "The Colour Out of Space" (1927) a meteorite falls on the Gardner farm west of Arkham, and the scientists who examine it find a substance that answers to none of their tests; within it is a globule whose hue was such that "it was only by analogy that they called it colour at all." In Uexküll's vocabulary the colour is a *Merkmal* without a *Merkorgan*: a cue for which the human functional circle has no receptor, which therefore registers only as a quasi-sign, colour by analogy, a disturbance of the categories rather than an instance of them. It closes no functional circle and releases no appropriate action. The Gardners do not flee, fight, or adapt; they sicken, go mad, and crumble into a gray brittle dust, and the vegetation of the farm takes on the unnamable tint before collapsing in the same way. The inversion of Freud is complete. Where the protective shield is dead matter that preserves life, the breach of the aperture converts life into dead matter. The blasted heath that remains, a gray waste on which nothing grows, is the landscape of a punctured *Umwelt*.

6.4 *Poor in World: Heidegger, Agamben, and the Anthropological Machine Reversed*

In his Freiburg lecture course of 1929–30, published in 1983 as *Die Grundbegriffe der Metaphysik*, Heidegger drew explicitly on Uexküll to formulate three theses: the stone is worldless, the animal is poor in world, the human being is world-forming. The animal is not without a world, but it is held in a condition Heidegger calls captivation (*Benommenheit*), absorbed by a disinhibiting ring of cues that release its behavior without ever disclosing beings *as* beings. His example is the bee that continues to suck honey after its abdomen has been severed, unable to register that the honey is flowing out behind it: it is taken by the food and cannot apprehend its presence as such. The human being alone relates to beings as beings, through the "as"-structure of understanding, and therefore forms a world.

Lovecraft's fiction extends Heidegger's scale upward and thereby dissolves it. Before the Great Race, whose archives span the history of the solar system and

whose minds traverse time, humanity is poor in world. Its "as"-structure is revealed as a wider disinhibiting ring, and its world-formation as a more capacious captivation. If the difference between human world-formation and animal world-poverty can be reproduced one level higher, between the Great Race and humanity, then it was never the essential difference Heidegger required but a difference of degree. The tales are a *reductio* of the anthropological difference. Giorgio Agamben's *The Open* (2002) describes the "anthropological machine" by which Western thought produces the human by isolating and excluding the animal within it. Lovecraft runs the machine in reverse. In *At the Mountains of Madness* the human appears in the records of the Elder Things as the animal excluded by another species' self-definition, a proto-mammalian creature used for food and as a source of amusement; and Dyer's conclusion that the Elder Things "were men" includes the alien in the human at the very moment the human has been excluded from the alien. The machine jams in both directions.

Agamben's title recalls the Eighth of Rilke's *Duino Elegies* (1923): *Mit allen Augen sieht die Kreatur / das Offene*, with all its eyes the creature sees the Open, while our eyes are as if turned around. Heidegger rejected Rilke's attribution of the Open to the animal. Lovecraft's position is more radical than either. The Open, in the sense of unmediated exposure to what is, is exactly what no creature can bear, and our turned-around eyes are the mercy. The aperture is the organ of our refusal of the Open.

6.5 *Fitness against Truth*

The evolutionary account of the aperture was stated by Konrad Lorenz in 1941, in an essay on "Kant's Doctrine of the A Priori in the Light of Contemporary Biology." The forms of intuition and the categories of the understanding, Lorenz argued, are a priori for the individual but a posteriori for the species: they are adaptations, fitted to the world as the hoof of the horse is fitted to the ground of the steppe and the fin of the fish to water. They are therefore true of reality only in the sense in which a hoof is true of the steppe, adequately for the purposes of a particular organism in a particular niche. Helmholtz's beings on curved surfaces, discussed in Chapter 2, here acquire a phylogeny. More recently Donald Hoffman's *The Case Against Reality* (2019) has argued, on the basis of evolutionary game-theoretic simulations whose interpretation remains contested, that perceptual strategies tuned to fitness systematically

outcompete strategies tuned to truth, so that perception is best understood as an interface whose icons conceal the structure of what they represent.

Lovecraft adds to this tradition a proposition it does not contain. For Lorenz the aperture is merely partial; for Hoffman the truth it conceals would be useless, as the voltages beneath a computer's desktop are useless to its user. For Lovecraft the truth is neither merely partial nor merely useless but lethal, and the reason lies in the fifth proposition of the founding paragraph. What correlation discloses is not only reality but "our frightful position therein." The aperture regulates not only what the organism perceives of the world but how the organism models itself, and a model of the world that ceased to be fitted to the organism would also cease to contain the organism as anything it could recognize or value. Fitness beats truth because truth, at sufficient scale, does not include the fit.

6.6 *The Four Defenses: Zapffe's "The Last Messiah"*

The most exact philosophical counterpart of the founding paragraph was written in Norwegian seven years later. Peter Wessel Zapffe's "Den sidste Messias" (1933) argues that human consciousness is an evolutionary overdevelopment, comparable to the antlers of the extinct Irish elk, which grew so heavy that they became a burden to the species that bore them. Consciousness has given humanity a capacity to perceive its cosmic situation that exceeds its capacity to bear what it perceives, and civilization survives only by artificially limiting the contents of consciousness. Zapffe enumerates four mechanisms of limitation: *isolation*, the dismissal of disturbing thoughts from awareness; *anchoring*, the fixation of attention on stable points such as God, the Church, the State, morality, or the future; *distraction*, the capture of attention by a constant stream of impressions; and *sublimation*, the transformation of despair into art.

The four mechanisms map onto Lovecraft's world with remarkable completeness. Isolation is the condition of the sciences, each straining in its own direction and none permitted to look over its neighbor's wall. Anchoring is the ethics of tradition reconstructed in Chapter 4, the little spheres of inherited value. Distraction is the placidity of the island itself, the ordinary life of Arkham and Providence. Sublimation is weird fiction, and here the mapping resolves the second paradox of the Introduction. Zapffe remarks that his own essay is an instance of sublimation, since its author is not suffering but filling pages for

publication. Lovecraft the author possessed all four defenses and above all the fourth: he contemplated cosmic insignificance with equanimity because he converted it into art. His narrators are subjects from whom the first three defenses have been stripped by events, and who possess the fourth only in a degraded form. They write, but their manuscripts do not save them. The serene author and the shattered narrator are the same subject with and without sublimation.

6.7 *Art as Shield: "The Music of Erich Zann"*

"The Music of Erich Zann" (1921) is the paradigm of sublimation as defense, and of its limits. A student lodging in the Rue d'Auseil, a steep street whose name can be read as *au seuil*, at the threshold, hears nightly from the garret above him the music of a mute German violist. Zann's garret has the only window on the street high enough to look over the wall at its summit, and Zann keeps it curtained. When the narrator finally looks through it he sees not the city but the blackness of space illimitable, alive with motion and with music unlike anything on earth. Zann's playing, increasingly frantic, is directed at that window: it answers something, or holds it back. In the climactic darkness the narrator stills the "mechanical nodding" of the violist's head and finds his face ice-cold and unbreathing, its eyes bulging sightlessly into the void. The music that held the Outside at bay had been sustained by a dead man.

The scene is Freud's vesicle rendered as allegory. The shield between the room and the void is art, and the artist who maintains it has already become part of the dead layer, the insensible surface that protects what lies behind it. It is also Schopenhauer inverted, as Chapter 4 anticipated: music in Schopenhauer is the direct copy of the will, whereas Zann's music is a barrier against what lies beyond representation. The frame of the tale completes the theory. The narrator has since examined the maps of the city with the greatest care and has never again found the Rue d'Auseil. The breach closes by erasing its own location. Forgetting is the aperture's mechanism of repair, and the "new dark age" of the founding paragraph is prefigured on the scale of a single street.

6.8 *The Double Valuation and the Phenomenology of Horror*

Lovecraft never settled the value of the aperture, and his indecision is constitutive of the genre. In “Supernatural Horror in Literature” (1927) the fixed laws of nature are “our only safeguard” against chaos. In “Notes on Writing Weird Fiction” (1933) the same laws are “galling limitations” of time, space, and natural law that imprison us and frustrate our curiosity about the cosmic spaces beyond the reach of sight and analysis. The aperture is both shield and prison, and the weird tale satisfies both valuations at once. It grants the illusion of transgression, gratifying the curiosity the prison frustrates, while its plot punishes the transgression, confirming the necessity of the shield. The weird tale is a controlled breach: a sample of the Outside admitted within the protective frame of fiction, in the manner of Freud’s feelers, which take in small quantities of the external world and withdraw. Weird fiction is culture’s feeler, and its characteristic affect is the affect of contact.

That affect can now be defined. Heidegger’s *Being and Time* (1927) distinguishes fear (*Furcht*), whose object is a determinate threat within the world, from anxiety (*Angst*), whose “object” is nothing within the world but being-in-the-world as such. Lovecraftian horror fits neither category. It has a determinate object, unlike anxiety; but its object is not within the world, unlike fear. Horror is anxiety with an object: the registration, by a creature whose world is an *Umwelt*, of a determinate thing that belongs to no *Umwelt* it could inhabit. This is why horror in Lovecraft is always accompanied by the failure of naming. The unnamable, as Chapter 5 argued, is the logical form of that exteriority, and the adjectival excess of the climaxes is the phenomenology of a shield registering its own perforation.

The theory of the aperture leaves one question open. If the danger is correlation, the synthesis of what the mind already contains, then the decisive event is not the arrival of the monster but the act by which someone assembles the evidence. The next chapter examines that act.

07

Correlation as Catastrophe

Documentary Form, Synthesis, and the Arche-Fossil

In Lovecraft's mature fiction the catastrophe is not the monster but the synthesis: the act by which a correlator assembles dispersed evidence into an intolerable whole. The form of the tales follows from this principle. They are archives, compiled from manuscripts, letters, clippings, depositions, photographs, and recordings, and their protagonist is the one who collates. This chapter anatomizes the documentary machine, reads its logic against Quentin Meillassoux's critique of correlationism, and argues that the present has transferred the act of correlation from human beings to machines, thereby revoking the mercy described in the founding paragraph of "The Call of Cthulhu."

7.1 *The Anatomy of a Dossier*

"The Call of Cthulhu" presents itself as a document "Found Among the Papers of the Late Francis Wayland Thurston, of Boston," and its three parts are three archives. The first, "The Horror in Clay," consists of the papers of Thurston's grand-uncle George Gammell Angell, professor emeritus of Semitic languages at Brown University, who died in the winter of 1926–27: a bas-relief modeled in dream by the young sculptor Henry Anthony Wilcox, who brought it to Angell on 1 March 1925; Angell's notes on Wilcox's fevered dreams; the results of Angell's inquiry among his acquaintances, which found that in the weeks that followed businessmen reported almost nothing, scientists little, and artists and

poets a great deal; and a file of press cuttings recording panics, suicides, and outbreaks of madness across the world in the same weeks. The second, "The Tale of Inspector Legrasse," is Angell's record of the 1908 meeting of the American Archaeological Society in St. Louis, at which a New Orleans police inspector produced a statuette seized in a raid on a swamp cult on 1 November 1907, and at which the Princeton anthropologist William Channing Webb recognized the cultists' chant from a tribe he had encountered in West Greenland in 1860. The third, "The Madness from the Sea," is Thurston's own discovery: an Australian newspaper of 18 April 1925 reporting the recovery of a derelict yacht and its sole survivor, the Norwegian sailor Gustaf Johansen, whose manuscript Thurston obtains from his widow in Oslo after Johansen's mysterious death.

No single archive contains the revelation. Angell possessed the dream and the cult but not the event; Legrasse possessed the cult but not the dreams; Johansen possessed the event but not its meaning. The catastrophe occurs in Thurston's study when the dates align: the earthquake of late February 1925 and the onset of the dreams, the landing on the risen city on 23 March, the cessation of Wilcox's delirium on 2 April, when, it appears, the city sank again. Thurston names the mechanism in his introductory paragraphs: his glimpse of forbidden aeons came from "an accidental piecing together of separated things," an old newspaper item and the notes of a dead professor. The monster appears only in the third part and only at second hand, in a sailor's manuscript summarized by Thurston; what the reader witnesses directly is not Cthulhu but correlation.

The form implicates the reader. Thurston closes by praying that, should he not survive his manuscript, his executors will put caution before audacity and see that it meets "no other eye." Every reader of the tale is that other eye. The text exists only because its executors disobeyed its author, and to read it is to repeat the forbidden synthesis with the assembled dossier in hand. "The Call of Cthulhu" is a document whose existence violates its own final instruction, and its reader is constituted as the last correlator in the chain.

7.2 *The Documentary Machine*

The architecture recurs throughout the mature fiction, with variations that map the available technologies of correlation. "The Dunwich Horror" (1928) turns on a library and a cipher. Wilbur Whateley comes to Miskatonic University to consult its Latin *Necronomicon*, in the version attributed to Olaus Wormius, and is refused by the librarian Henry Armitage, who later decrypts Wilbur's journal with the aid of the old cryptographic authorities and so learns what Wilbur and his invisible twin intend. The university library is at once the center of correlation and its censor: it holds the dangerous text, restricts access to it, and trains the only scholars able to decode what the text makes possible. It is an institutional aperture.

The Case of Charles Dexter Ward (1927) is a novel of archival reconstruction in which Ward, and after him his physician Marinus Bicknell Willett, reassemble the life of Joseph Curwen from colonial letters, court records, diaries, and papers hidden behind the paneling of Curwen's old house. Its epigraph, attributed to Borellus, supplies the most literal image of necronomics in the corpus: the "essential Saltes" of animals and human beings may be so prepared and preserved that an ingenious man may have "the whole Ark of Noah in his own Studie" and raise the shape of any dead ancestor from its dust. Curwen's laboratory, with its labeled jars of salts, is an archive of the dead organized for interrogation, a database of persons from which knowledge can be extracted on demand. Chapter 12 returns to this image.

"The Shadow out of Time" (written 1934–35) completes the series by turning the archive upon the archivist. Nathaniel Wingate Peaslee, a professor of political economy at Miskatonic, suffers an amnesia of five years (1908–1913) during which, he later comes to understand, his body was occupied by a mind of the Great Race while his own mind lived as a captive scholar in their world, some 150 million years in the past. In 1935 an expedition to the Great Sandy Desert of Western Australia uncovers the ruins; Peaslee descends alone into the archives, locates the case he was assigned, and finds within it a record written in English, in his own handwriting. The final synthesis is not the discovery of an alien civilization but the discovery of the correlator as an entry in its catalog. The subject who assembles the evidence learns that he has already been assembled.

Across these variations a single form persists: an archive of dispersed traces, a correlator whose curiosity outruns his caution, and a terminal sentence, frequently italicized, in which the traces fuse into a proposition the correlator cannot survive knowing. Poe's single effect, as Chapter 5 argued, has become a single synthesis, and plot has become the history of an assembly.

7.3 *The Civilization of Correlation*

The Great Race of Yith is the one civilization in Lovecraft's cosmos that has made correlation its form of life. Its archives contain the histories of every epoch of the solar system, written by the captive minds of those epochs themselves, each compelled to record its own age in its own language for deposit in metal cases. The Great Race survives what destroys human correlators because its *Umwelt* is wide enough to contain what it correlates: its minds move through time, and the history of the cosmos is for them not a revelation but a reference collection. The contrast defines the human predicament precisely. Correlation is catastrophic not in itself but relative to the aperture of the correlator.

Jorge Luis Borges's "The Library of Babel" (1941) supplies the complementary figure. Its universe is a library containing every possible book of a fixed length, and therefore every truth and every falsehood, every catalog and every refutation of every catalog. Its librarians despair because meaning drowns in combinatorial noise: the true account of anything is present somewhere, but indistinguishable from its infinitely many corruptions. The library of the Great Race is the opposite extreme. It contains only true accounts, recorded by witnesses, and is lethal for that reason. Babel is total noise and the Yithian archive total signal, and the human mind is protected from both by the same aperture. We survive in the narrow middle, where there is enough signal to live and too little to be destroyed.

7.4 *The Arche-Fossil and the Arche-Archive*

Quentin Meillassoux's *Après la finitude* (2006; translated by Ray Brassier as *After Finitude*, 2008) defines correlationism as the thesis, dominant in philosophy since Kant, that we have access only to the correlation between thinking and being and never to either term considered apart from the other. Against it Meillassoux sets the *arche-fossil*: a material indication of a reality anterior to the

emergence of life and thought, such as the radiometric dating of rocks older than any organism or the measured age of the universe. Science makes ancestral statements, statements about a time when there was no one to whom anything was given, and correlationism, Meillassoux argues, cannot take them literally without contradiction. What it has lost is what he calls the great outdoors, the absolute exterior that pre-critical thought could explore as a domain indifferent to whether it was thought.

Lovecraft's fiction is full of arche-fossils, and it alters their nature in a way that bears directly on Meillassoux's argument. The specimens Lake's expedition extracts from the Antarctic strata, the basalt blocks of the Great Race's buried city, and the cyclopean masonry of R'lyeh are traces of a time before humanity, but not of a time before thought. They are records of prior minds. Lovecraft's ancestral is not the absence of the correlation but its plurality: the earth was correlated, long before us, by beings to whom it was given in forms we cannot share. His arche-fossils are arche-archives.

The consequence cuts against correlationism from an unexpected direction. Meillassoux attacks correlationism for being unable to think a world without thought. Lovecraft attacks it by thinking a world full of thought that is not ours. If correlation is the universal structure of access, then the Great Race and the Elder Things are correlators too, and the human correlation loses its transcendental privilege: it becomes one *Umwelt* among others, a biological fact rather than a condition of possibility. The great outdoors, in Lovecraft, is not empty. It is inhabited, and its inhabitants are the evidence that our form of access is local. Meillassoux's own positive thesis, the absolute contingency of every law under a hyper-chaos capable of destroying any order and producing anything whatever, reads in this light like a gloss on the idiot god at the center of infinity, with the difference that Lovecraft's physics remains stable enough to be known. Meillassoux has distinguished science fiction, whose worlds remain accessible to experimental science, from what he calls extro-science fiction, whose worlds are too irregular for science to exist. Lovecraft belongs to neither category. His is the fiction of a science that succeeds, and whose success is unbearable to the one who achieves it.

7.5 *Media of the Dead*

Friedrich Kittler's *Grammophon Film Typewriter* (1986) argues that the technical media of the decades around 1900 separated the data streams of sound, image, and writing, stored the real rather than its symbolic transcription, and bound themselves from the outset to the realm of the dead, whose extent, Kittler proposes, is as large as the storage and transmission capacities of a culture. Lovecraft's fiction registers this media revolution with unusual fidelity. In "The Statement of Randolph Carter" (1919) Carter waits above ground while Harley Warren descends into an ancient tomb trailing a telephone wire; Warren's reports grow frantic and cease, and a voice that is not his speaks up the line: "YOU FOOL, WARREN IS DEAD!" The telephone into the grave is the medium of the dead in its literal form.

"The Whisperer in Darkness" (written 1930) is, a half-century before Kittler, an inventory of his three media. It contains a phonograph record of a ritual in the Vermont woods on which human voices alternate with a buzzing imitation of human speech; photographs of alien footprints and of a black stone inscribed with unknown characters; and a final typewritten letter, conspicuously unlike its handwritten predecessors, which proves to be a forgery. Its climax discloses the ultimate storage medium: the metal cylinders in which the fungoid visitors transport human brains across space, connected to devices for sight, hearing, and speech. The cylinder is the phonograph of the mind, converting a person into a portable data carrier. Kittler's thesis that the so-called human being was split around 1900 into physiology and information technology here receives its Gothic literalization.

7.6 *Delegated Correlation*

The founding paragraph located humanity's safety in an incapacity: the mind's inability to correlate its contents, and the sciences' failure to integrate their results. Both conditions have been altered by computation. In 2008 Chris Anderson's essay "The End of Theory," published in *Wired*, argued that at sufficient scale correlation makes causal models unnecessary, since patterns extracted from data can predict without explaining. Whatever the merits of that claim, and they have been widely disputed, its vocabulary is Lovecraft's. Correlation is now performed on dissociated knowledge at a scale no human

synthesizer could approach, and its results are delivered to subjects who did not perform the synthesis and frequently cannot audit it.

Necronomics names the structural novelty of this situation. The founding paragraph imagined a human correlator destroyed by what he assembled. The present produces correlation without a correlator: a synthesis performed by no one in particular, as the law of the dead is a law without legislators and the mercy of the founding paragraph a mercy without anyone merciful. The merciful inability, which the story treated as a fixed feature of the human condition, turns out to have been a contingent limitation of processing capacity, and it has been lifted by delegation rather than by any change in the human aperture. Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006), examined in Chapter 10, imagines the resulting figure with precision in its narrator, a "synthesist" whose profession is to summarize for his superiors the outputs of minds and machines he does not understand. Chapter 12 states the consequence as the seventh theorem.

In one respect the documentary machine has always been harmless, and the exception is instructive. The readers who have correlated the Mythos itself, compiling its gods, books, and chronologies into encyclopedias, rule-books, and fan concordances, have performed on a vast scale the synthesis the narrators feared, and have survived it, because what they correlated was fiction. Their harmless correlation is the subject of the next chapter, which asks what becomes of myth when its function is inverted, and what becomes of the inverted myth when a culture domesticates it.

08

Counter-Mythology

Materialist Theogony and Inverted Gnosis

Lovecraft was a materialist who invented a pantheon, and the paradox dissolves once the function of his mythology is distinguished from its form. In form the Mythos is a mythology: it has gods, genealogies, sacred books, cults, rites, and an eschatology. In function it is the inverse of myth. Where myth, on the most developed modern theory, reduces the pressure of an overwhelming reality by naming its powers, dividing them, and holding them at a distance, Lovecraft's counter-mythology names in order to expose, concentrates rather than divides, and brings the distant near. It is the form in which, as Chapter 4 put it, the true world can be spoken by a creature bound to fables.

8.1 *The Work of Myth and Its Reversal*

Hans Blumenberg's *Arbeit am Mythos* (1979; translated as *Work on Myth*, 1985) begins from a hypothetical primal situation he calls the absolutism of reality: a condition in which human beings did not control the conditions of their existence and, more importantly, believed that they did not. Myth is the first and most durable technique for reducing that absolutism. It works by naming, since what is named can be addressed, bargained with, or avoided; by dividing, since a pantheon distributes overwhelming power among many figures whose rivalries limit one another; and by storytelling, which converts the timeless menace of the powers into a sequence of past events. Its central psychological

achievement, in Blumenberg's account, is the rationalization of anxiety, which has no object, into fear, which has one. Myth gives the unknown a face, and a face can be feared, placated, and eventually mocked.

Lovecraft's counter-mythology reverses each operation. Its names do not render the powers addressable. "Cthulhu," "Yog-Sothoth," and "Nyarlathotep" are constructed to resist human articulation, and in a letter of 1934 Lovecraft explained that the first was a clumsy human approximation of a word formed by organs unlike ours, offering only a guttural approximation of its sound. The name marks the limit of address rather than its possibility. Its pantheon does not divide power in any way that limits it: the Outer Gods do not check one another, and their hierarchy, where it exists, is a gradient of indifference. Its stories do not relegate the menace to the past. The Old Ones sleep rather than die, and their return is scheduled by the periodicities of celestial mechanics. Above all, the counter-myth reverses the psychological achievement. Chapter 6 defined Lovecraftian horror as anxiety with an object. Blumenberg's myth converts anxiety into fear by supplying an object that belongs to the world; Lovecraft's converts fear back into anxiety while retaining the object, by supplying an object that belongs to no world we could inhabit. The name remains, but it names what cannot be faced.

Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944; 1947) supplies the complementary thesis: myth is already enlightenment, and enlightenment reverts to mythology. Lovecraft's fiction is a precise instance of the second half of the formula. Enlightenment, pursued to its limit in cosmology and biology, produces a knowledge the knowing creature cannot inhabit, and that knowledge reverts to mythic form because myth is the only form in which a creature of *nomos* can hold what exceeds it. Horkheimer and Adorno's reading of the episode of the Sirens is apposite. Odysseus has himself bound to the mast so that he may hear the song without following it, while his oarsmen, their ears stopped with wax, row on without hearing. The episode is an allegory of the merciful aperture and of Zapffe's sublimation: the bound listener enjoys the song as art, and the laboring many are protected by deafness. Lovecraft the author is Odysseus at the mast. His narrators are oarsmen who have removed the wax.

8.2 A *Materialist Theogony*

The principle that generates the pantheon was identified in Chapter 5 as evolutionary euhemerism: the gods of legend are distorted memories of nonhuman organisms. "The Call of Cthulhu" adds the mechanism of distortion. The cultist Castro testifies that the Great Old Ones communicated with the first men by shaping their dreams, and the entire first part of the tale documents a dream-transmission from the sunken city to the sensitives of 1925. Myth is the dream-work of contact. Freud's *The Interpretation of Dreams* (1900) described the condensations and displacements by which the dream disguises its latent content, and Freud elsewhere treated myths as distorted vestiges of collective wishful fantasy. In Lovecraft the latent content of myth is not a wish but a fact, a physical encounter that human cognition could register only by condensing it into gods and displacing it into ritual. The theogony is materialist in this exact sense: each deity is the dream-distorted image of a physical or biological reality.

ENTITY	PRINCIPAL APPEARANCES	MYTHIC FIGURE	SCIENTIFIC OR PHILOSOPHICAL REFERENT	LINEAGE
Azathoth	*The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath* (1926–27); "The Haunter of the Dark" (1935)	Blind idiot sultan at the center of infinity, lulled by drums and flutes	Undirected physical chaos; energy without purpose	Schopenhauer's will; Dunsany's Mana-Yood-Sushai
Yog-Sothoth	*The Case of Charles Dexter Ward* (1927); "The Dunwich Horror" (1928); "Through the Gates of the Silver Key" (1932–33)	The gate, the key, and the guardian of the gate; the All-in-One	The four-dimensional continuum in which all times coexist	Minkowski's space-time (1908); Hinton's fourth dimension; the Neoplatonic One
Nyarlathotep	"Nyarlathotep" (1920); *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath* (1926–27); "The Haunter of the Dark" (1935)	Messenger of the Outer Gods, a showman who speaks human language and wears human form	Mediation itself: the interface through which the Outside addresses the human	Hermes and Thoth; the electrical lecturer; the dream of 1920
Shub-Niggurath	"The Whisperer in Darkness" (1930) and several revisions	The Black Goat of the Woods with a Thousand Young	Fecundity without form; life as indiscriminate proliferation	Huxley's protoplasm; Machen's Pan; the Great Mother

ENTITY	PRINCIPAL APPEARANCES	MYTHIC FIGURE	SCIENTIFIC OR PHILOSOPHICAL REFERENT	LINEAGE
Cthulhu	"The Call of Cthulhu" (1926)	Priest of the Old Ones, dead yet dreaming in sunken R'lyeh	The deep past that persists and returns: tectonic, oceanic, and psychic depth	Tennyson's "The Kraken" (1830); Leviathan; the Freudian unconscious

The table permits several observations. Azathoth is the only member of the pantheon without a message, since chaos has nothing to communicate; Nyarlathotep is the only member that speaks, and he speaks as a showman. In the prose poem "Nyarlathotep" (1920), written from a dream, the god arrives in the guise of a lecturer: "And it was then that Nyarlathotep came out of Egypt," exhibiting strange instruments of glass and metal and demonstrations of electricity before audiences who leave in terror. The messenger of the Outer Gods is a figure of technological mediation, and the century that followed has made his mode of address its own. Yog-Sothoth is the most abstract of the entities and the most precise. The *Necronomicon* passage quoted in "The Dunwich Horror" declares that "Yog-Sothoth is the gate," the key and the guardian of the gate, in whom past, present, and future are one; in "Through the Gates of the Silver Key" the entity is encountered as an all-in-one in which every moment of Randolph Carter's existence, and of every other existence, is simultaneously present. Hermann Minkowski's lecture of 1908, which announced that space by itself and time by itself were doomed to fade into mere shadows, supplied the physics. Yog-Sothoth is the block universe given a name and a cult.

Cthulhu, finally, condenses three depths. The first is geological: R'lyeh rises in an earthquake and sinks again. The second is oceanic, and Tennyson's sonnet "The Kraken" (1830) is its most exact literary ancestor, with one revealing difference. Tennyson's monster sleeps "His ancient, dreamless, uninvaded sleep" until the latter fire shall heat the deep. Lovecraft's decisive addition is the dream: Cthulhu sleeps and dreams, and his dreams invade others. The third depth is therefore psychic. A being that is dead and yet dreams, and communicates through the dreams of the sensitive, is the return of the repressed with a physical address. The cult's formula, which Legrasse's prisoners chant and which the tale translates, reads "In his house at R'lyeh dead Cthulhu waits dreaming," and it is the necronomic sentence par excellence: a statement about the dead that is at once a law, a condition, and a threat.

8.3 *Inverted Gnosis*

Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958), developed from his *Gnosis und spätantiker Geist* (1934), reconstructs the Gnostic myth as the drama of a soul imprisoned in a cosmos made by an ignorant or malevolent demiurge, sunk in sleep, intoxication, and forgetfulness, and awakened by a call that comes from an alien God beyond the world. Revelation is knowledge (*gnosis*) of one's true origin, and knowledge saves: it frees the divine spark to return, through the hostile spheres, to the fullness (*pleroma*) from which it fell into the emptiness (*kenoma*) of the material world. The Hymn of the Pearl in the apocryphal Acts of Thomas gives the drama its most beautiful form: a prince sent into Egypt falls asleep and forgets his mission until a letter from his parents flies to him in the likeness of an eagle, becomes speech, and wakes him.

Lovecraft's fiction reproduces the Gnostic structure and inverts every value within it. It too presents human life as a sleep within an alien cosmos, and its central tale is named for a call. But the call of Cthulhu comes from a sleeping god rather than a waking one; it reaches human beings in their dreams rather than waking them from dreams; and it summons them not upward toward the light but downward into the deep. Knowledge, which in Gnosticism saves, in Lovecraft damns: the recognition of one's true origin is not the recovery of a divine spark but the discovery of descent from the slime, the fish, or the laboratory residue of Chapter 3. Most strikingly, the Gnostic topography is reversed. The *kenoma*, the emptiness of the material cosmos, turns out in Lovecraft to be full, a pleroma of monsters, and the knowledge that reveals its fullness is the lethal *gnosis*. Lovecraft's is a Gnosticism of the *kenoma*.

Jonas saw the modern significance of this structure in the essay he appended to the second edition of his book, "Gnosticism, Existentialism, and Nihilism." Modern nihilism, he argued, repeats the Gnostic experience of human estrangement from the cosmos, with one decisive difference: the Gnostic cosmos was hostile, an anti-divine order that at least took notice of the soul it imprisoned, while the modern cosmos, after Pascal's infinite spaces and the physics of indifferent law, is merely indifferent. The difference defines Lovecraft's position with precision. His philosophy is the modern nihilism of the indifferent cosmos; his fiction clothes it in the imagery of Gnostic demonology, because hostility is the only form in which indifference can be felt. An

indifferent cosmos provides no object for horror. The Old Ones supply one, and they are indifferent at close range.

The couplet that Lovecraft placed first in "The Nameless City" (1921) and repeated in "The Call of Cthulhu" seals the inversion: "That is not dead which can eternal lie, / And with strange aeons even death may die." The couplet parodies Christian eschatology, in which death is the last enemy to be destroyed and John Donne can proclaim, "Death, thou shalt die." In Donne death dies by resurrection; in Lovecraft it dies by the strange aeons of deep time, which relativize even the law that ends every organism. Rudolf Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) had defined the numinous as the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, the experience of a "wholly other" that both repels and attracts. Lovecraft retains the wholly other, the *tremendum*, and, as Chapter 9 will show, the *fascinans*; he removes only the holy. His numinous is naturalized: the wholly other is a biological and physical other, and the creature-feeling it provokes is the feeling of being a creature among other creatures rather than before a creator.

8.4 *The Return of Myth: Derleth, the Circle, and the Domestication of the Outside*

If Blumenberg is right, the work of myth does not cease when a counter-myth is written. It resumes on the counter-myth itself, and the subsequent history of the Mythos is the empirical test of the fourth theorem. The work began within Lovecraft's lifetime and with his encouragement. He invited his correspondents to borrow his names and borrowed theirs in return: Clark Ashton Smith contributed Tsathoggua and the Book of Eibon, Robert E. Howard the *Unaussprechlichen Kulten* of von Junzt, Robert Bloch the *De Vermis Mysteriis* of Ludvig Prinn. Bloch's "The Shambler from the Stars" (1935) killed off a character modeled on Lovecraft, and Lovecraft replied with "The Haunter of the Dark," whose victim is named Robert Blake. The shared mythology functioned as an open-source archive whose reality effect derived from mutual citation, since a book mentioned by three authors seems to exist independently of each of them. The Mythos became, in the terms of the Introduction, a *nomos* without legislators.

After Lovecraft's death August Derleth undertook the work of myth in Blumenberg's precise sense. He named the whole the "Cthulhu Mythos," classified its entities by element, and divided its powers, opposing benevolent Elder Gods to malevolent Great Old Ones in a cosmic war. Derleth also

circulated, as a statement of Lovecraft's intentions, a passage describing an elder race expelled for practicing black magic and waiting to reclaim the earth; later scholarship traced it not to any surviving letter of Lovecraft's but to the recollection of a correspondent, Harold S. Farnese. The re-mythologization thus began with an apocryphal scripture. Its seed lay in Lovecraft's own work, for "The Dunwich Horror" (1928), with its victorious librarian, its protective incantations, and its explicit moral that such things must not be called in from outside, is the most Derlethian tale he wrote. Critics from Tierney and Mosig onward have treated Derleth's dualism as a betrayal. The necronomic reading treats it as a confirmation. The counter-myth was re-domesticated because domestication is what myth does, and Derleth's division of powers is the oldest technique for reducing absolutism applied to the newest absolute.

The work continued in popular culture. Chaosium's role-playing game *Call of Cthulhu* (1981) converted the merciful aperture into a quantity, a Sanity score that investigators spend as they encounter the Mythos, so that the breach of the aperture became a resource to be managed. Occultists converted the fiction into practice: Kenneth Grant's *The Magical Revival* (1972) read Lovecraft as an unwitting visionary of the Crowleyan current, Anton LaVey's *The Satanic Rituals* (1972) included Lovecraftian ceremonies composed by Michael Aquino, and a grimoire published in 1977 under the pseudonym "Simon" presented itself as the *Necronomicon*, blending Mesopotamian myth with Lovecraft's names and selling widely in paperback. The theorists of the Cybernetic Culture Research Unit later called such fictions that make themselves real *hyperstitions*, and the *Necronomicon*, an invented book that now exists in several published forms, is their paradigm. At the far end of the process stand the plush Cthulhus and cartoon tentacles of the souvenir trade. The last phase of the work on myth is the reduction of the monstrous to play, and the stuffed toy is its terminal product: the absolutism of the Outside rendered soft enough to hold.

The domestication does not refute the counter-myth. It enacts, on the scale of a culture, the second exit of the founding paragraph, the flight from the deadly light into the peace and safety of a new dark age, conducted not by forgetting but by play. The Mythos has survived as a mythology precisely to the extent that it has ceased to function as a counter-mythology, and its readers, who correlate it without harm, confirm that correlation is catastrophic only when what is correlated is true. What happens when the defended interior, rather than the cosmos, becomes the object of correlation is the subject of the next chapter.

09

The Autoimmune Cosmos

Genealogy, Race, and the Outside Within

The fourth mechanism of necronomics is autoimmune. Throughout Lovecraft's fiction a defended interior, whether a self, a lineage, a race, a gender, a species, or a culture, mobilizes against an Outside and discovers, at the moment of maximal defense, that it was constituted by what it defends against. This chapter formalizes the structure through Roberto Esposito's theory of *immunitas* and Jacques Derrida's concept of autoimmunity, and uses it to address the most contested question in Lovecraft studies: the relation between his cosmic horror and his racism. It argues that the racism is neither an incidental blemish nor the hidden engine of the work but the displacement of necronomic panic onto the social field; that the fiction's structure dismantles the purity its affect defends; and that beneath the xenophobia of the tales runs a xenophilic telos, a desire for the Outside that the horror both expresses and censors.

9.1 *Immunitas*

Esposito's *Immunitas* (2002) derives both community and immunity from the Latin *munus*, the obligation, office, or gift that binds the members of a *communitas* to one another. *Immunitas* is exemption from the *munus*: the immune person is released from the obligations that bind others. Modern politics, Esposito argues, is organized by the immunitary paradigm, which protects life by exposing it to a controlled portion of what threatens it, as a

vaccine protects the body by introducing a weakened pathogen. Protection is achieved through negation, and the protective apparatus carries within it the possibility of turning against what it protects. Derrida, in "Faith and Knowledge" (1996) and the writings that followed, generalized this possibility as autoimmunity: the process by which a living being, in an almost suicidal logic, works to destroy its own protection and turns its defenses against itself.

Lovecraft's fiction is an anthology of autoimmune events, and it displays the structure in two forms. In the first, the defense attacks the self because the self turns out to be the enemy: the investigator hunting the monster discovers that he is its descendant, its twin, its record, or its by-product. In the second, the defense itself is the vector through which the enemy enters, as Chapter 4 showed in the antiquarian piety of Charles Dexter Ward, whose devotion to his ancestors resurrects the one who destroys him. In both forms the boundary between inside and outside is not breached from without. It is revealed never to have existed where it was defended.

9.2 A *Catalogue of Recognitions*

The anagnorisis that Chapter 5 traced from Bierce's Carcosa recurs with such regularity that it can be catalogued by the interior it dissolves. The *self* dissolves in "The Outsider" (1921), where the narrator who has fled a monster's presence touches a mirror and learns that the monster is himself. The *lineage* dissolves in "Arthur Jermyn" (1920), where the last of an aristocratic house learns that an ancestor married the white ape-goddess of a lost Congo city, and in "The Rats in the Walls" (1923), where the restorer of an ancestral seat learns that his forebears farmed human beings as cattle and becomes, in the tale's final scene, a cannibal himself. The *race* dissolves in "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (written 1931), where the narrator's genealogical tour of New England ends in the discovery that he is descended from the Marsh family and the Deep Ones. The *family* dissolves in "The Dunwich Horror," whose final sentence discloses the nature of the thing destroyed on Sentinel Hill: "It was his twin brother, but it looked more like the father than he did." *Gender* is the defended interior of "The Thing on the Doorstep" (written 1933), in which a man's body is seized by a sorcerer who had previously occupied the body of his own daughter, and whose horror turns on the violation of a masculine self by a mind that had lived as a woman. The *individual mind* dissolves in "The Shadow out of Time," where the scholar finds his own handwriting in an alien archive. The *species* dissolves in At

the Mountains of Madness, where terrestrial life, humanity included, is revealed as the by-product of an alien laboratory. And *culture* dissolves in "The Call of Cthulhu," where the most refined organs of civilization, its artists and poets, turn out to be the receivers through which a sleeping god transmits his dreams.

The catalogue establishes the generality of the structure. Lovecraft did not have a horror of heredity, a horror of race, and a horror of the cosmos that happened to share imagery. He had a single structure, the discovery of the Outside within, which he applied to every interior his culture had taught him to defend. This is why the racial and the cosmic horrors can neither be separated by excision, as a sanitizing criticism would wish, nor collapsed into one another, as a purely political criticism tends to do. They are applications of one operation to different domains.

9.3 *The Burrow and the Walls*

In 1923 two writers who never read one another composed the same parable. Lovecraft's "The Rats in the Walls," written that summer, concerns a man who restores his ancestral home as a fortress of continuity and begins to hear, within its walls, the scurrying of rats that only he and his cats can perceive; pursuing the sound downward, he finds the ancestral crypts and his own atavism. Kafka's "Der Bau" ("The Burrow"), written in the winter of 1923–24 and left unfinished at his death, concerns a creature that has perfected an underground dwelling against every conceivable enemy and begins to hear, within its walls, a faint whistling it cannot locate. The more it excavates in search of the source, the more its fortifications are undone by the search, and the more it suspects that the noise is the approach of a great beast, or else a property of the burrow itself. The two texts share a structure that neither author could have taken from the other: the perfection of a defense produces the perception of an internal threat, and the pursuit of the threat destroys the defense. Kafka's creature never learns whether the noise comes from outside or inside. Lovecraft's narrator learns that the distinction was never valid. The rats are in the walls because the walls were built on the pit.

9.4 *Race as Displaced Necronomic Panic*

Lovecraft's racism is extensively documented, and no account of his philosophy is complete without it. It appears first in "On the Creation of Niggers" (1912), a short poem in which the gods, having shaped man in Jove's image and designed the beasts for lesser parts, fashion a beast in semi-human form, fill it with vice, and set it in the gap between the two: a racial theogony that assigns Black people an intermediate rank between the human and the animal. It runs through letters of every period, antisemitic as well as anti-Black and anti-immigrant, and reaches particular virulence in the correspondence of his New York years, 1924–1926, when he lived in Brooklyn after his marriage to Sonia Haft Greene, a Jewish émigré from Ukraine, and experienced the immigrant city as an assault on the Anglo-American continuity with which he identified. The fiction of those years translates the experience into horror. "The Horror at Red Hook" (1925) catalogues the district's "Syrian, Spanish, Italian, and negro elements" as a single contagion and ends with evil still brooding "amongst the mongrels" in its old brick houses. "He" (1925) shows the city's future overrun by "yellow, squint-eyed people," an explicitly anti-Asian figure rather than a coded one. The pattern predates New York. "Herbert West—Reanimator" (1922) describes a Black boxer, Buck Robinson, as "a loathsome, gorilla-like thing," and the narrator's black cat in "The Rats in the Walls" is named "Nigger-Man," the name of Lovecraft's own childhood cat: the compound fixes a racial slur and the word for a human being to an animal. "Medusa's Coil" (1930), ghostwritten for Zealia Bishop, reserves as its climactic revelation the heroine's partial African ancestry. The "Innsmouth look" is, among other things, a figure of miscegenation panic, and even "The Call of Cthulhu" describes the cult's Louisiana worshippers as "men of a very low, mixed-blooded, and mentally aberrant type." In his last years Lovecraft's economic politics moved toward support for the New Deal; his racial hierarchy did not move with them. In 1933 he wrote to J. Vernon Shea that New York was "virtually lost to the national fabric" through its "tragic & all-pervasive Semitisation" (29 May), and, answering newspaper clippings about Hitler that Shea had sent him, judged the new German chancellor an extremist who was nonetheless "fighting against a real evil," while maintaining that civilization depends on segregation and that some races are morphologically and psychologically more primitive than others (25 September).

Two interpretive errors must be avoided. The first, common in the older scholarship, treats the racism as an unfortunate prejudice of the period, detachable from a philosophy that would remain intact without it. The fiction refutes this reading, since several of its central tales derive their affective charge from racial fear. The second, formulated most powerfully by Michel Houellebecq, treats racial hatred as the hidden engine of the work, of which cosmic horror would be the sublimated expression. The chronology and the corpus tell against this reading as well, though less cleanly than its critics usually allow. The cosmic horror is fully formed in texts in which race plays no part, such as "The Colour Out of Space" and "The Music of Erich Zann," and the materialism that grounds it derives from Haeckel, Elliot, and astronomy rather than from social resentment. Yet race is not confined to the lesser tales: it enters the founding text of the mythos itself, in the racial description of the Louisiana cult. Racial hatred is not the engine of the cosmic horror, but it is not absent from its center.

The necronomic account holds that the racism is the displacement of cosmic panic onto the social field. A subject who had grasped, earlier and more acutely than most, that the human interior was a transient stratum in an indifferent cosmos, and who defended against that knowledge by anchoring himself in a narrowly defined cultural and racial continuity, experienced every perceived threat to that continuity with the full force of the cosmic threat for which it stood. Chapter 4 named the defense *Umwelt*-conservatism; racism is its pathological hypertrophy, the conversion of an ecological defense of the familiar into a paranoid defense of the pure. Two qualifications follow. The 1912 poem shows that the hierarchy was in place before the cosmic fiction existed: the displacement did not create the racial scale of being, which Lovecraft took from the race science of his milieu, but recharged it with cosmic terror. And to explain the racism in this way is not to excuse it. The displacement directed the terror produced by a true insight onto people who had nothing to do with its cause. In the letters it licensed Lovecraft's descriptions of Jewish, Black, and immigrant Americans as dangers to the nation's culture, and in 1933 it licensed his endorsement of segregation and his qualified sympathy for the aims of the new Nazi government.

The fiction stands in a double relation to the displacement. At the level of affect it frequently intensifies racial panic, and a reader who takes the horror at face value receives the paranoia intact. At the level of structure it dismantles the purity the panic defends. Donald Burleson's deconstructive readings have shown how the tales undo their own oppositions, and the logic of deep time, as

Chapter 3 argued, is fatal to every myth of pure origin: if every stratum is transient and every descent impure, there is no depth at which the defended interior was ever uncontaminated. The Innsmouth narrator's discovery that he is a Marsh is the discovery that the distinction on which his revulsion rested was never real. The structure knows what the affect refuses to know.

9.5 *The Thalassal Telos*

The final pages of "The Shadow over Innsmouth" transform the structure from horror into desire. The narrator, who has fled the town in terror and learned of his ancestry, feels the change beginning in his body and dreams of the undersea city. He considers suicide and rejects it. He resolves instead to free his cousin from an asylum and go with him to the reef, to descend to the city of the Deep Ones and dwell there "amidst wonder and glory for ever." The tale ends not in horror but in exaltation, and the exaltation is not ironic.

Sándor Ferenczi's *Versuch einer Genitaltheorie* (1924), translated as *Thalassa*, had proposed that human sexuality expresses a *thalassal regressive trend*, a biological longing to return to the marine existence from which terrestrial life emerged, of which the return to the womb is only the individual symbol. Freud's *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) opens with a discussion of the "oceanic feeling," the sensation of limitless unity described to him by Romain Rolland, which Freud traced to the infantile condition before the boundaries of the ego were drawn. *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* had already posited a death drive whose aim is the return of the living to the inorganic: *Das Ziel alles Lebens ist der Tod*, the aim of all life is death. The Innsmouth narrator's descent condenses all three: a return to the sea, a dissolution of the ego's boundaries, and a passage beyond the individual life into an older and larger one.

The ending is not unique. It is the most explicit instance of a pattern of crossings that runs through the corpus. The Outsider, having recognized himself in the mirror, ends by riding "with the mocking and friendly ghouls on the night-wind." Kuranes in "Celephaïs" (1920) dies in the waking world, his body washed up near an English village called Innsmouth, the first appearance of the name in Lovecraft's work, and reigns forever in the city of his dreams. Randolph Carter passes through the gate of the silver key into Yog-Sothoth. In "The Whisperer in Darkness" the voice from the chair, speaking as Akeley, urges Wilmarth to accept the visitors' offer of transport to Yuggoth as a brain in a cylinder, and the tale's horror is inseparable from the seductiveness of the offer.

The late fiction also extends to the alien a sympathy the early fiction withheld: Dyer's judgment on the Elder Things; the rational order of the Great Race in "The Shadow out of Time," which the narrator describes, in Lovecraft's political vocabulary of the moment, as a "fascistic socialism"; and "In the Walls of Eryx" (1936, written with Kenneth Sterling), whose dying narrator, trapped in an invisible labyrinth on Venus, comes to regard the reptilian natives he has hunted for their crystals as intelligent beings with a claim to their world.

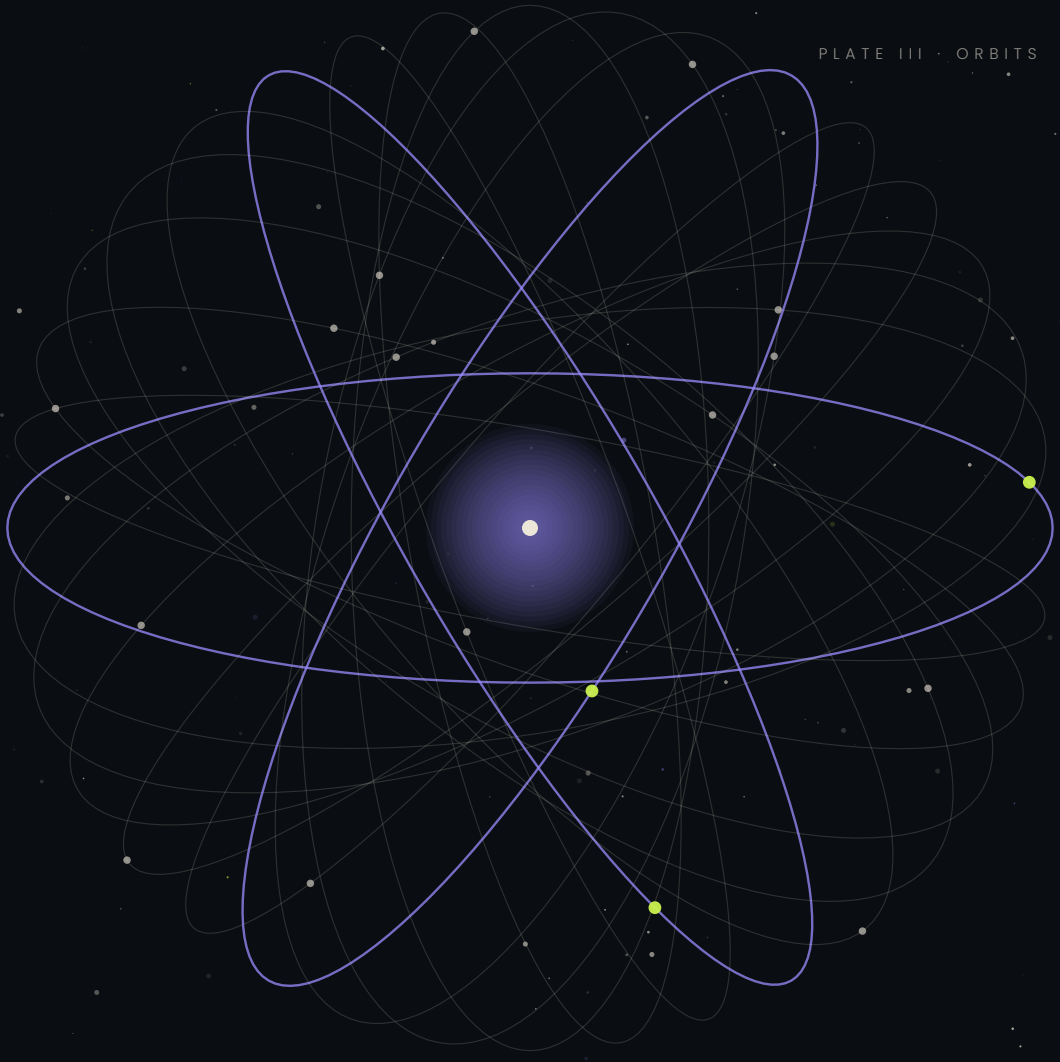
The pattern warrants a thesis that this dissertation calls the *thalassal telos*. Xenophobia is the conscious affect of Lovecraft's tales; xenophilia is their narrative destination. Horror is the censored form of a desire for the Outside, the form that desire takes in a subject whose interior is organized to refuse it. Otto's *fascinans*, which Chapter 8 held in reserve, returns here: the wholly other attracts as it repels, and the tales end, with remarkable frequency, with their narrators crossing over. The autoimmune cosmos is not only a structure of self-destruction. It is also a structure of self-exceeding, in which the defended interior discovers that it belongs to the Outside and, in its most daring moments, consents.

9.6 *Re-Umwelting: The Counter-Writings*

The most significant response to the autoimmune structure has come not from criticism but from fiction. Victor LaValle's *The Ballad of Black Tom* (2016) retells "The Horror at Red Hook" from the standpoint of a Black hustler from Harlem, for whom the indifference of the cosmos is less terrifying than the violence of the police. Matt Ruff's *Lovecraft Country* (2016) sets the Mythos in Jim Crow America, where the cosmic horrors are recognizably continuous with the social ones. Ruthanna Emrys's *Winter Tide* (2017) makes the Deep Ones' descendants a persecuted minority, survivors of the government's raid on Innsmouth interned in a desert camp alongside Japanese Americans. N. K. Jemisin's *The City We Became* (2020) assigns the role of the cosmic Enemy to an entity that embodies the colonizing logic Lovecraft's fiction often served. Alan Moore and Jacen Burrows's *Providence* (2015–2017) follows a gay Jewish journalist of 1919 through a landscape assembled from the tales, discovering the Mythos as the hidden structure of American modernity.

These works perform an operation that may be called *re-Umwelting*. They reconstruct from the inside the worlds the original tales presented only from outside, as threat, and so demonstrate that the Outside of one *Umwelt* is the

inside of another. In doing so they complete, in a direction Lovecraft did not take, the logic his own late fiction began: the recognition that the monster has a world, which is the political form of Dyer's conclusion that the Elder Things were men. They do not abandon cosmic indifference. They show that the terror it produces is misdirected when it is turned against neighbors, and that the only defensible response to the discovery of the Outside within is to widen the circle of the interior. With this the four structural mechanisms are complete. Part Three situates them among the philosophical science fictions and speculative philosophies that have inherited Lovecraft's predicament.



PART THREE

III Afterlives

10 The Alien without Anthropomorphism
11 The Weird Turn

10

The Alien without Anthropomorphism

Lovecraft among the Philosophical Science Fictions

In 1934 Lovecraft set the philosophical science fiction of the following century its task: to represent the alien without anthropomorphism, and so to present, within a human narrative, an order that does not share the human form. This chapter reads the major philosophical science fictions from Wells to Liu Cixin as a series of answers to the predicament necronomics describes. Each takes a posture toward the law of the dead, and together they compose a typology in which Lovecraft's horror appears not as the genre's primitive emotion but as one position among several, defined by its relation to the aperture.

10.1 *The Program of 1934 and the Theory of the Genre*

"Some Notes on Interplanetary Fiction" (written 1934) condemns the conventional space adventure for populating other worlds with beings who are human in all but trivial details: who speak, love, scheme, and fight as we do, and whose strangeness is costume. Lovecraft demands instead that other worlds and their inhabitants be rendered as genuinely other, with motives and perceptions beyond human sympathy, and that the true subject of such fiction be the emotion of cosmic strangeness itself, conveyed with scrupulous realism. The essay is the program of the alien without anthropomorphism, and Chapter 4

has shown why it can be executed only negatively: truth, on Nietzsche's account, is an army of anthropomorphisms, and the non-anthropomorphic can appear in language only as the failure of its categories.

Academic theory of science fiction has found this program difficult to classify. Darko Suvin's *Metamorphoses of Science Fiction* (1979) defined the genre by *cognitive estrangement*: the presentation of a *novum*, a novelty that estranges the reader's world while remaining validated by cognition, that is, by the logic of a scientific worldview. Suvin excluded fantasy and horror from the genre as anti-cognitive, and Lovecraft's weird has usually been exiled with them. China Miéville's "Cognition as Ideology" (2009) replied that the "cognition" of science fiction is largely a rhetorical effect, an authority conferred by the text's claim to scientific plausibility, so that the border between science fiction and fantasy is ideological rather than epistemological. Necronomics suggests a more precise placement. Lovecraft's novum is fully cognitive in origin, derived from astronomy, geology, and biology, and fully validated by the scientific worldview; what distinguishes it is that it cannot be assimilated by the subject who meets it. It is a *negative novum*: a novelty whose cognitive validation is total and whose cognitive assimilation is impossible. Istvan Csicsery-Ronay's *The Seven Beauties of Science Fiction* (2008), which counts the science-fictional sublime and grotesque among the genre's constitutive pleasures, names the two affects in which the negative novum is registered: the sublime of scale and the grotesque of form.

10.2 *Wells and Stapledon: The Microscope and the Star Maker*

H. G. Wells's *The War of the Worlds* (1898) opens with the image that governs cosmic fiction thereafter: humanity scrutinized, as a man with a microscope scrutinizes the creatures that swarm in a drop of water, by "intellects vast and cool and unsympathetic." The Martians are the posthuman future of the human, enormous brains atrophied of body, and the narrator explicitly compares their treatment of England to the European extermination of the Tasmanians. Wells's cosmic indifference is thus already colonial in its self-understanding, and its resolution is immunological: the invaders are destroyed by terrestrial bacteria against which they have no defense. Lovecraft's cosmos contains no such bacteria. Nothing in his fiction protects humanity except its ignorance, and the immune system that saves Wells's England is, in Lovecraft, the merciful aperture.

Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937) extend the cosmic scale beyond anything in Lovecraft: two billion years of human history across eighteen species, and then the whole history of the cosmos, culminating in a vision of its creator. Stapledon's Star Maker is an artist who makes and discards universes and contemplates his creatures' agonies with dispassionate aesthetic attention, and the narrator's response is worship: an adoration that expects no love in return and finds the creator's indifference itself worthy of reverence. It is unnecessary to establish that Lovecraft read Stapledon to recognize the relation. Stapledon occupies the posture that Lovecraft's narrators cannot reach and his author declined: the consecration of indifference.

10.3 *Clarke and Dick: Prolepsis and Salvation*

Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) offers the most exact reversal of Lovecraft's theory of myth. Its Overlords, who supervise humanity's final transformation, resemble the devils of human iconography, and the novel explains the resemblance not as a memory of an ancient encounter but as a racial premonition, a memory running backward from humanity's end. Lovecraft's myths are anamnesis, the distorted memory of contact in the deep past; Clarke's are prolepsis. The difference in temporal direction corresponds to a difference in value. The Overlords are midwives, and the children of the last generation pass into a cosmic Overmind in an apotheosis that their parents, and the Overlords themselves, can witness but not share. Clarke's cosmos, like Lovecraft's, exceeds the human; unlike Lovecraft's, it has a place prepared for what the human becomes.

Philip K. Dick's VALIS (1981) restores the Gnostic structure that Chapter 8 found inverted in Lovecraft. Its protagonist, Horselover Fat, is struck by a beam of pink light that transmits information from a Vast Active Living Intelligence System, and the novel, drawing on Dick's own experiences of February and March 1974, treats the transmission as a call that awakens the sleeping soul in the Black Iron Prison of the world. Knowledge in Dick saves, or at least promises to. The two writers agree in their estimate of the world as a prison and differ in the direction of the call: in Dick it comes from a living intelligence that seeks to free us, in Lovecraft from a dreaming one that does not know we exist.

10.4 *Lem: The Science of the Unknowable*

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) is the most rigorous meditation on the alien without anthropomorphism in the literature, and it can be read as Lovecraft's scenario conducted by a rational institution. The planet's ocean is a single entity whose activity generates vast structures that a century of "Solaristics" has classified, named, and theorized without understanding. The station's library holds the discipline's immense bibliography, including a body of discredited testimony the Solarists call apocrypha: a Miskatonic of the rational sciences, complete with its own suppressed texts. When the ocean responds to human probing, it does so by materializing figures drawn from the researchers' most painful memories, and the physicist Snaut draws the conclusion that humanity does not seek other worlds at all, only mirrors of itself. The contact fails because the aperture cannot be overcome, only confronted: every attempt to know the ocean returns an image of the knower.

The novel ends with a theological speculation that marks its distance from Lovecraft with precision. Kelvin imagines an imperfect god, a being whose limitation is intrinsic to it, perhaps a god in its infancy, and wonders whether the ocean might be such a being. Lovecraft's Azathoth is an idiot god, perfect in its indifference; Lem's is an imperfect god, perhaps capable of development and even of despair. The posture of *Solaris* is humility: a fallibilist science that knows its categories to be anthropomorphic and persists nonetheless, mapping the aperture from within. *His Master's Voice* (1968), in which a team of scientists spends years decoding a signal from space and extracts from it only a substance whose meaning they cannot establish, generalizes the lesson. The alien message becomes a projective test, and the history of its interpretation a history of human projection.

10.5 *The Strugatskys: Litter and Irony*

Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972) supplies the most deflationary of the postures. Visitors from space have come and gone, leaving behind six Zones in which physical law is locally deranged and artifacts of incomprehensible function lie scattered. The scientist Valentine Pilman proposes that the Visitation was a picnic: travelers stopped by the roadside, left their litter, and went on, and the creatures of the roadside, humanity among

them, now scavenge the debris. The Zone is Lovecraft's blasted heath enlarged into a political economy. Its contaminated ground marks the children of the stalkers who enter it, and its effects extend to the dead, who rise from the cemeteries within its boundaries and walk home. The law of the dead is suspended here by an accident of alien waste. The posture is irony in Nagel's sense: the Visitors did not even notice us, and the appropriate response is neither terror nor worship but the wry and dangerous labor of scavenging at the margin of an indifference too large to resent.

10.6 *Ballard and VanderMeer: Metamorphosis*

J. G. Ballard's *The Drowned World* (1962) develops the thalassal telos of Chapter 9 into a complete fiction. As rising temperatures return the earth to a Triassic climate and London sinks beneath tropical lagoons, the characters' dreams regress through the evolutionary past, and the novel's scientist proposes that the nervous system preserves the memory of every epoch through which life has passed, so that the changing environment awakens an archaeopsychic descent. The protagonist ends by walking south into the jungle, toward the sun, accepting the regression that Lovecraft's narrators flee until the last pages of "The Shadow over Innsmouth." Jeff VanderMeer's Southern Reach trilogy (2014) completes the metamorphic posture. Area X is a coastal region in which an alien agency is transforming the landscape and those who enter it, and the Southern Reach, the secret agency charged with studying and containing it, is an immune bureaucracy that fails autoimmunely, penetrated and transformed by what it guards against. The trilogy's final volume is titled *Acceptance*, and its protagonists pass through horror into an acquiescence in becoming other. VanderMeer supplies what Lovecraft's fiction reached only in its endings: a narrative in which metamorphosis is the ground rather than the climax.

10.7 *Watts and Liu: Strategy and the End of the Subject*

Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006) carries the theory of the aperture to its limit by asking whether the subject who suffers the breach is necessary at all. Its aliens, the scramblers, are intelligent, adaptive, and entirely without consciousness, and the novel proposes, drawing on Thomas Metzinger's self-model theory of subjectivity, that consciousness is an evolutionary accident, a costly overhead that intelligence can do without. Two inversions follow. First, the human crew's

transmissions, dense with self-referential meaning, register to the scramblers as an attack, an information hazard that wastes their resources: the human is the alien's unnamable. Second, the ship's commander is a vampire, a resurrected predator species driven to extinction by a neurological flaw, the "crucifix glitch," which triggers seizures at the sight of intersecting right angles, so that the spread of Euclidean architecture through human settlement sealed the vampires' fate. Where R'lyeh's non-Euclidean angles break the human mind, the Euclidean angles of human cities broke another. Geometry, as Chapter 2 concluded, is an ecological parameter of cognition. The novel's narrator, Siri Keeton, is the synthesist anticipated in Chapter 7: a correlator who summarizes what he does not understand.

Liu Cixin's trilogy, begun with *The Three-Body Problem* (2006; English 2014) and completed by *The Dark Forest* (2008) and *Death's End* (2010), is the most systematic modern rewriting of the Lovecraftian situation. It begins with a message from a Trisolaran pacifist warning humanity, three times, not to answer, and with the astrophysicist Ye Wenjie, embittered by the Cultural Revolution, answering anyway. The Earth-Trisolaris Organization that grows from her reply is Lovecraft's Cthulhu cult modernized: a secret society of human beings who welcome the alien, some wishing humanity destroyed, others worshipping the invaders as redeemers. The first volume's physicist Yang Dong kills herself after sabotaged experiments persuade her that physics has never existed, a Lovecraftian madness born of the apparent failure of natural law. *The Dark Forest* formulates a cosmic sociology in which every civilization is a hidden hunter and any civilization that reveals its location is destroyed. This is the bidirectional aperture of "From Beyond" and "The Willows" raised to galactic strategy: to be perceived is to die, and survival requires silence. *Death's End* discloses, finally, that the physical constants of the present universe, its three dimensions and the speed of light, are the ruins of ancient wars in which civilizations used the laws of physics as weapons. The laws of nature are war damage. Liu literalizes the title of this dissertation: the laws that govern the living are the relics of the dead.

10.8 *Borges: The Architecture of the Other Body*

Jorge Luis Borges dedicated "There Are More Things" (1975) to Lovecraft's memory while describing him, in the afterword to the collection, as an involuntary parodist of Poe, and the tale's homage is correspondingly exact and ironic. Its narrator returns to his late uncle's house, remodeled by a mysterious new owner, and enters it at night to find furniture and ramps whose shapes presuppose a body no human being possesses; the horror consists entirely in the inference from artifact to anatomy, and the being itself is glimpsed only as it ascends a ramp. The method is Lovecraft's own. In "The Nameless City" (1921) the narrator crawls through passages too low for a human being to stand and deduces, before he sees their images, that the builders were not men but crawling things. Borges isolates this technique, the representation of the alien through the negative imprint it leaves on space, as the essence of the Lovecraftian alien: a body known only as the shape of what it needs.

10.9 *A Typology of Postures*

The comparisons compose a typology. Each posture defines a relation between a knowing subject and an order that holds without it, and each can be characterized by its affect, its epistemic stance, and its relation to the aperture.

POSTURE	EXEMPLARY TEXTS	CHARACTERISTIC AFFECT	EPISTEMIC STANCE	RELATION TO THE APERTURE
Horror	Lovecraft's narrators	Dread, nausea, the unnamable	Knowledge is lethal	Breached from outside and suffered
Ataraxia	Lucretius; Lovecraft's letters	Serenity, irony	Knowledge is therapy	Widened voluntarily and contemplated from within
Worship	Stapledon, *Star Maker*	Adoration without reciprocity	Contemplation of indifference	Breached and consecrated
Salvation	Clarke, *Childhood's End*; Dick, *VALIS*	Ecstasy, grief	Knowledge saves the species or the elect	Exceeded by transformation from above
Humility	Lem, *Solaris*; *His Master's Voice*	Melancholy, tenacity	Fallibilist science aware of its anthropomorphism	Mapped from within as a limit

POSTURE	EXEMPLARY TEXTS	CHARACTERISTIC AFFECT	EPISTEMIC STANCE	RELATION TO THE APERTURE
Irony	Strugatskys, *Roadside Picnic*; Nagel	Wry, bitter detachment	The Outside as indifferent debris	Exploited at its margins
Revolt	Russell, "A Free Man's Worship"; Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*	Defiance, lucidity	Refusal of consolation	Held open by an act of will
Strategy	Liu Cixin, *The Dark Forest*	Vigilance, dread	Cosmic game theory	Converted into concealment
Metamorphosis	"The Shadow over Innsmouth"; Ballard, *The Drowned World*; VanderMeer, Southern Reach	Fascination, acceptance	Knowledge transforms the knower	Dissolved by becoming other
Abolition of the subject	Watts, *Blindsight*	None	Intelligence without experience	Eliminated with the subject who could suffer its breach

The typology clarifies Lovecraft's position in two ways. First, his work occupies not one cell but two, horror in the fiction and ataraxia in the letters, and the gap between them is the gap the Conclusion will seek to close. Second, his fiction contains the germs of several other postures at its margins: worship in the cultists, metamorphosis in the Innsmouth ending, irony in the indifference of the Old Ones, strategy in Dyer's plea that the Antarctic be left undisturbed. Lovecraft's horror is less one posture among others than the zero point from which the others depart, the affect of a subject meeting the law of the dead before it has chosen how to live with it. The next chapter follows the same predicament into philosophy, where the choice has become explicit.

11

The Weird Turn

Speculative Realism, Dark Ecology, and the Horror of Philosophy

Since the first decade of this century Lovecraft has been read less as a writer who had a philosophy than as a philosopher who wrote fiction. This chapter examines that reception, here called the weird turn, and argues that necronomics both belongs to it and corrects it. The weird turn has largely read Lovecraft for his ontology or his mood; necronomics reads him for a structure, the aperture and its breach by correlation, that neither ontology nor mood alone can capture. The correction yields specific results: speculative realism, in its most influential version, ontologizes the mercy that Lovecraft's fiction shows failing; the philosophy of extinction pronounces the verdict his indifferentism withheld; dark ecology rewrites his telos; and the theory of the eerie supplies the grammar of the law of the dead.

11.1 *A Patron Saint for Realism*

The Speculative Realism workshop held at Goldsmiths, University of London, on 27 April 2007 brought together Ray Brassier, Iain Hamilton Grant, Graham Harman, and Quentin Meillassoux, whose projects shared little beyond the rejection of the correlationism described in Chapter 7. Lovecraft became the movement's unofficial patron almost at once, and the journal *Collapse*, which published the workshop's proceedings, devoted its fourth volume, *Concept Horror* (2008), to the weird. The adoption is intelligible. A philosophy that wishes to think the world independently of its givenness to human beings needs

an imaginative archive of that world, and Lovecraft's fiction is the richest such archive in modern letters.

The background of the adoption reaches back to two texts of Lovecraft's own lifetime. Max Weber's lecture "Science as a Vocation" (delivered 1917, published 1919) described modernity as the disenchantment of the world: the conviction that there are in principle no mysterious incalculable forces, and that all things can be mastered by calculation. Lovecraft's fiction completes disenchantment and produces from it a second enchantment. The calculable, pursued far enough, discloses what calculation reveals but cannot master, and the Mythos is the form enchantment takes when it returns through the door that science opened. Edmund Husserl's *Crisis of European Sciences*, whose first parts appeared in 1936, the year *At the Mountains of Madness* and "The Shadow out of Time" appeared in *Astounding Stories*, diagnosed the same situation from the opposite side. Galilean science, Husserl argued, had substituted a mathematically idealized nature for the lifeworld (*Lebenswelt*) in which all meaning is rooted, clothing the world in a garb of ideas and forgetting its own origin in lived experience; the crisis could be overcome only by returning science to its ground in the lifeworld. Lovecraft's fiction denies that the lifeworld can serve as ground. The lifeworld is the aperture, the placid island, and the mathematized nature Husserl wished to subordinate to it is the law of the dead, which holds whether or not any lifeworld survives. Husserl and Lovecraft agree on the diagnosis and disagree on the direction of priority.

11.2 *Harman's Gaps and the Ontologization of Mercy*

Graham Harman's *Weird Realism: Lovecraft and Philosophy* (2012), anticipated in his essay "On the Horror of Phenomenology: Lovecraft and Husserl" (2008), is the most sustained philosophical reading of Lovecraft yet attempted. Harman's object-oriented ontology holds that real objects withdraw from every relation, including every act of knowledge, so that no description exhausts a thing. Lovecraft, he argues, is the writer of gaps. His prose opens a vertical gap between an object and its qualities by alluding to a thing that exceeds any description of it, as when the idol of Cthulhu is evoked through simultaneous images of an octopus, a dragon, and a human caricature that the narrator immediately treats as merely suggestive; and a horizontal gap between an object and the profusion of its features, as in the cubist accumulation of anatomical detail with which Dyer describes the Elder Things. Harman's method is to

rewrite a hundred passages in flat paraphrase and so demonstrate that the literary effect lies precisely in the gaps the paraphrase closes.

The reading is illuminating at the level of the sentence, and the level of the sentence is its limit. Harman's analysis largely brackets the plot, and the plot is where Lovecraft's philosophy is enacted: in the documentary assembly of Chapter 7 and the synthesis that ends it. A deeper difficulty follows. For Harman, withdrawal is an ontological law: no object is ever fully present to another, and the real is inexhaustible in principle. Lovecraft's horror depends on the failure of withdrawal. The catastrophe of "The Call of Cthulhu" is not that the real exceeds every description but that the dispersed descriptions correlate, that the real becomes available in a synthesis the correlator cannot survive. Object-oriented ontology converts the merciful aperture into a metaphysical guarantee, so that the mercy which Lovecraft's founding paragraph treats as a contingent and revocable incapacity becomes a structural feature of being. Harman's ontology is, in necronomic terms, an ontologization of mercy. Lovecraft's fiction is about the day the guarantee fails.

11.3 *Thacker, Brassier, Ligotti: The World without Us and the Verdict*

Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011), the first volume of his *Horror of Philosophy*, distinguishes three concepts of world: the world-for-us, the human world of meaning, which he calls the World; the world-in-itself, which becomes available to us only as it resists us, and which he calls the Earth; and the world-without-us, the Planet, which is the subtraction of the human altogether and can be thought only at the limit of thought. Horror, for Thacker, is the genre in which the world-without-us is thought as a problem for the world-for-us. Necronomics adds one element to the triad. The Lovecraftian scene is not the world-without-us but the world-without-us-with-us-in-it: the Planet as it appears to a witness who has not yet been subtracted. The narrator is the indispensable anomaly, a remnant of the World surviving inside the Planet long enough to write it down, and horror is the affect of that survival.

Ray Brassier's *Nihil Unbound: Enlightenment and Extinction* (2007) draws the most rigorous consequence from the same premises. The eventual extinction of the sun, Brassier argues, is not merely a future event but a fact that retroactively cancels the meaning of every human project, so that everything is, in a sense, dead already, and philosophy should not console but should become

the organ of this truth. Brassier's is necronomics without the aperture: the law of the dead stated as the law of the present, with no protective incapacity interposed. Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy against the Human Race* (2010) takes a further step that Brassier does not. Building explicitly on Zapffe, whose four defenses Chapter 6 mapped onto Lovecraft's world, Ligotti argues that consciousness is a malignant accident and that bringing into existence beings who must suffer it is a harm, so that the honest response is the refusal of reproduction. Ligotti's pessimism is Schopenhauer's verdict renewed. Lovecraft, as Chapter 4 showed, withheld the verdict: a cosmos that intends nothing can be accused of nothing, and the discovery that existence has no cosmic value does not establish that it has negative value. The difference between Lovecraft and Ligotti is the difference between indifferentism and pessimism, and it is the difference on which the Conclusion's fourth path depends.

11.4 *Theory-Fiction: Negarestani, Land, Woodard*

A second current of the weird turn adopted not Lovecraft's cosmology but his form. Reza Negarestani's *Cyclonopedia: Complicity with Anonymous Materials* (2008) is built as a Lovecraftian dossier, assembled around the lost notes of a fictional Iranian archaeologist, and it uses the documentary machine of Chapter 7 to present petroleum as a quasi-sentient agent of Middle Eastern history and of modern war. Negarestani's "complicity" names an openness that consents to being cracked open by the Outside, the thalassal telos of Chapter 9 elevated into a method. The Cybernetic Culture Research Unit gathered around Nick Land at Warwick in the 1990s had already treated Lovecraft as a source of what it called hyperstition, fictions that function causally to make themselves real, and Ben Woodard's *Slime Dynamics* (2012) found in the protoplasmic imagery analyzed in Chapter 3 the basis for a dark vitalism in which life is formless, indifferent, and without privilege. In each case Lovecraft's documentary form became a method of philosophical writing, the found manuscript and the fictional scholar serving as instruments for thinking what academic prose cannot comfortably state. Theory-fiction is correlation practiced as a genre.

11.5 *Dark Ecology and the Chthulucene*

Timothy Morton's *Hyperobjects* (2013) names a class of entities massively distributed in time and space relative to human beings: global warming, radioactive materials, the biosphere. Hyperobjects are real but cannot be perceived as wholes. They are known only through their local manifestations, which must be correlated before their existence can be grasped. The epistemology of the hyperobject is the epistemology of "The Call of Cthulhu." A being too vast to be seen directly, whose presence is registered as a scatter of dreams, panics, suicides, and anomalous events across the world, becomes known only when someone assembles the dispersed records and recognizes their common source. Cthulhu is a hyperobject avant la lettre, and climate change is the Cthulhu of the present: its evidence was long distributed among specialized sciences, each straining in its own direction, until correlation disclosed our frightful position therein.

Morton's *Dark Ecology* (2016) describes ecological awareness as a loop that passes through three darknesses: the depressing darkness of guilt and dread, the uncanny darkness of strangeness, and finally a darkness that is sweet, an acceptance of coexistence with what we cannot master. The loop reproduces the affective trajectory of Lovecraft's fiction with remarkable fidelity, from horror, through the weird, to the thalassal sweetness of the Innsmouth ending. Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) completes the ecological rewriting from a position of explicit opposition. Her "Chthulucene," spelled to mark its distance from Lovecraft's monster, which she dismisses as a misogynist and racist nightmare, names an epoch of multispecies entanglement in which tentacular beings are figures of kinship rather than threat. Her emblem is a spider, *Pimoa cthulhu*, whose species name was borrowed from Lovecraft by the arachnologist who described it. Haraway performs in theory the re-Umwelting that Chapter 9 found in the counter-fictions: she keeps the tentacle and discards the horror, retaining the thalassal telos without its censorship. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari had anticipated the move in *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980), which cites "Through the Gates of the Silver Key" in its account of becoming and reads Carter's discovery of his own multiplicity across space-time as a paradigm of the self's alliance with the anomalous.

11.6 *The Weird, the Eerie, and the Grammar of Necronomics*

Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) distinguishes two modes of the outside. The weird is the presence of what does not belong, an intrusion that exceeds our categories and exerts, for all its wrongness, a fascination; Lovecraft is its exemplary author. The eerie arises from a failure of absence or a failure of presence, when there is something where there should be nothing or nothing where there should be something, and it is bound up with the question of agency: what is acting here, and whether there is an agent at all. Fisher's distinction clarifies a feature of necronomics that has recurred throughout this study. Its central figures are not only weird but eerie in Fisher's exact sense: a law without legislators, a mercy without anyone merciful, a correlation without a correlator, a mythology without authors, an archive that precedes its archivist. Each names an agency without an agent, a function performed by no one. This is the grammar of necronomics, and it explains why Lovecraft's fiction, though populated by monsters, is most disturbing where no one is acting at all.

11.7 *Revolt and Solidarity: Camus and Leopardi*

The weird turn has been richer in ontology than in ethics, and the two most important ethical responses to the Lovecraftian predicament were formulated outside it. Albert Camus's *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942) locates the absurd in the confrontation between the human call for meaning and the unreasonable silence of the world, and rejects both physical suicide and the philosophical suicide of the leap into faith in favor of revolt: a lucid refusal of consolation that lives on in full awareness of its situation. *Il faut imaginer Sisyphe heureux*, one must imagine Sisyphus happy. Lovecraft's world differs from Camus's in one respect that matters. It is not silent. In Camus the human calls and the world does not answer; in Lovecraft the world calls, in a register the human cannot bear, and the absurd accordingly becomes the weird. Camusian revolt nonetheless supplies one component of the ethics this dissertation seeks: the lucidity that neither flees into a new dark age nor collapses into madness.

The other component comes from a century earlier. Giacomo Leopardi's "Dialogue between Nature and an Icelander" (written 1824) stages the encounter of a man who has fled nature's cruelty across the globe with Nature herself, a gigantic woman who informs him that she never had the human species in view

and would not notice if she extinguished it. The Icelander's fate is uncertain: one report has him devoured by lions, another buried by a sandstorm and later exhibited, mummified, in a European museum. He ends, that is, as a specimen, a knower converted into an exhibit of the law of the dead. Leopardi's answer came in "La ginestra" (1836), in which the broom flower growing on the lava of Vesuvius figures a humanity that neither denies nor flatters its situation, and in which the only rational response to an indifferent nature is solidarity: the noble spirit regards all human beings, *tutti fra sé confederati*, as confederates against the common enemy. Revolt and solidarity, Camus's lucidity and Leopardi's confederation, are the two ethical inheritances the weird turn has left largely unclaimed. Part Four gathers the argument into seven theorems and asks whether they can be joined to what Lovecraft lived but never wrote.



PART FOUR

IV Necronomics

12 Seven Theorems of Necronomics

12

Seven Theorems of Necronomics

The preceding chapters reconstructed the genealogies of Lovecraft's thought, formalized its four structural mechanisms, and located them among the fictions and philosophies that have inherited its predicament. This chapter states the results as seven theorems. The word is used in the sense of a proposition derived from premises established earlier in the argument, not in the sense of a mathematical demonstration. Each theorem is stated, derived, extended by a corollary, and tested against the strongest objection it faces. Together they form a system: the first defines the object of necronomics, the second and third its epistemology, the fourth through sixth its cultural, political, and libidinal consequences, and the seventh its historical actuality.

12.1 *First Theorem: The Nomos*

> *The true is what remains invariant under the subtraction of the subject.*

Lovecraft's cosmic indifferentism is usually read as a mood or as a judgment of value. In its rigorous form it is a theory of truth. The theorem derives from three sources traced in Part One. The Democritean charter of Chapter 1 declared

sweetness, warmth, and color to exist by convention and atoms and void in reality, defining the real as what survives the subtraction of the perceiver's contribution. The physics of invariance examined in Chapter 2 gave that subtraction exact form: the objective is what holds under every admissible transformation of the observer's frame, and what holds for every observer holds for none in particular. Lovecraft's own letter to Farnsworth Wright of July 1927 drew the literary consequence, holding that genuine externality requires the writer to forget that human laws, interests, and emotions possess any validity in the cosmos at large. The limit of the series of transformations is the null observer, the frame in which no one is present. The law of the dead is the set of propositions that survive the subtraction of every living standpoint.

COROLLARY Value is not among the invariants. Every value is *nomos*, instituted and maintained by the living, and it does not follow that value is unreal; it is real as *nomos*, which is the premise of the ethics of tradition reconstructed in Chapter 4.

OBJECTION AND REPLY The correlationist objects that nothing can be known to hold without us, since all knowledge is a correlation between knower and known. The reply is that invariance is established within correlation, by varying the correlator: across instruments, frames of reference, and, in Lovecraft's decisive extension, species of mind. Chapter 7 showed that Lovecraft's arche-fossils are arche-archives, records of prior correlators, and that their existence converts the human correlation from a transcendental condition into one variable among others. The subtraction of the subject is performed not by a leap outside thought but by the multiplication of thinkers.

12.2 *Second Theorem: The Aperture*

> *The human lifeworld is an ecological niche of ignorance: a bounded region of the knowable, shaped by selection for fitness rather than truth, whose boundary protects the organism that inhabits it.*

The theorem restates the founding paragraph of "The Call of Cthulhu" in the vocabulary of its independent articulations: Freud's protective shield, formed by a dead outer layer that admits the world only in samples; Uexküll's *Umwelt*, the soap bubble of signs within which each organism lives; Heidegger's captivation,

which Lovecraft's fiction extends upward until human world-formation appears as a wider captivation; Lorenz's phylogenetic a priori and Hoffman's interface; and Zapffe's four mechanisms by which consciousness limits its own contents.

COROLLARIES Horror is the affect of the aperture's breach, defined in Chapter 6 as anxiety with an object: the registration of a determinate thing that belongs to no world the subject could inhabit. The unnamable is not a stylistic failure but the logical form of an input that exceeds the categories of the receiving system. And tradition, the "little spheres" of inherited value, is an aperture of the second order, protecting value as cognition protects truth.

OBJECTION AND REPLY Science widens the aperture continually and without catastrophe: the telescope, the microscope, and the Copernican reform itself were survived. The reply distinguishes two dimensions of widening. Science widens the aperture in the dimension of data while leaving intact the organism's model of itself as a center of value; catastrophe occurs when widening reaches the self-model, when "our frightful position therein" becomes one of the invariants. The Copernican, Darwinian, and Freudian blows were survived because each was compensated, as Blumenberg showed of the first, by a new centrality of the knowing subject. The noetic blow of Chapter 2 admits no compensation, since it demotes the knower in the act of knowing.

12.3 *Third Theorem: Correlation*

> *The catastrophe is not the encounter with the monster but the synthesis of dispersed knowledge: the act by which a correlator assembles what the division of epistemic labor had kept apart.*

The theorem derives from the documentary form analyzed in Chapter 7. In "The Call of Cthulhu" no single archive contains the revelation, the monster appears only at second hand, and the event the reader witnesses directly is the alignment of dates in Thurston's study. The pattern recurs in the cipher of "The Dunwich Horror," the colonial archive of *The Case of Charles Dexter Ward*, the recordings and forgeries of "The Whisperer in Darkness," and the handwriting in the archive of "The Shadow out of Time." Poe's single effect has become a single synthesis, and plot has become the history of an assembly.

COROLLARIES Catastrophe is relative to the aperture of the correlator: the Great Race, whose world is wide enough to contain the history of the solar system, correlates without harm. And reading participates in the catastrophe. The documentary form makes every reader the last correlator in the chain, the "other eye" that Thurston prayed his manuscript would never meet.

OBJECTION AND REPLY The readers of the Mythos correlate its dispersed texts on a vast scale and are not destroyed. The reply is that they correlate fiction, and the theorem concerns the synthesis of what is true. The harmless correlation of fiction is itself a protective structure: the controlled breach of Chapter 6, which admits a sample of the Outside within the frame of the known-to-be-invented.

12.4 *Fourth Theorem: The Counter-Myth*

> *Under conditions of scientific modernity, myth can be reengineered from a technology of distance into a vector of exposure. The counter-myth names the Outside in order to present it as unassimilable, converting fear back into anxiety while retaining an object.*

The theorem derives from Chapter 8. Blumenberg's myth reduces the absolutism of reality by naming, dividing, narrating, and distancing its powers, and so rationalizes anxiety into fear. Lovecraft's counter-myth reverses each operation: its names resist address, its pantheon does not limit its powers, its gods sleep rather than die, and its object belongs to no inhabitable world. Its theogony is materialist, each deity the dream-distorted image of a physical or biological reality, and its Gnosticism is inverted, a call from a sleeping god that damns rather than saves.

COROLLARY The counter-myth is unstable. The work of myth resumes upon it and re-domesticates it, and the domestication confirms the theorem by exhibiting the mythic function reasserting itself.

OBJECTION AND REPLY A theorem confirmed both by the counter-myth and by its domestication appears unfalsifiable. The reply specifies what would falsify it: a counter-myth that retained its exposing function indefinitely under popular transmission, or a domestication that did not proceed by the Blumenbergian

techniques. The history of the Mythos exhibits those techniques in order: naming and mutual citation in Lovecraft's circle; the division of powers in Derleth's Elder Gods and Great Old Ones; narrativization and quantification in the games; reduction to play in the plush toy. The theorem predicted a sequence, and the sequence occurred.

12.5 *Fifth Theorem: Autoimmunity*

> *Every defense of an interior against the Outside terminates in the recognition that the interior was constituted by the Outside, and the defense itself is the vector of that recognition.*

The theorem derives from the catalogue of Chapter 9, in which the self, the lineage, the race, the family, the gender, the individual mind, the species, and the culture are each defended and each dissolved, and from Esposito's and Derrida's accounts of immunity as protection by negation and of autoimmunity as the turning of protection against the protected. Its paradigm is the antiquarian who resurrects the ancestor who destroys him.

COROLLARY Lovecraft's racism is the displacement of necronomic panic onto the social field: the hypertrophy of *Umwelt*-conservatism into a paranoid defense of purity. At the level of affect the fiction frequently intensifies that panic; at the level of structure it dismantles the purity the panic defends, since deep time admits no pure origin at any depth.

OBJECTION AND REPLY To explain racism as displaced cosmic panic may seem to aestheticize or excuse it. The reply is that the theorem explains a mechanism without excusing a choice. The displacement directed a terror produced by a true insight onto human beings who bore no relation to its cause, and it is to be judged as such. The theorem also makes a prediction that a mere excuse would not: racial panic in the fiction should prove self-undermining at the level of structure. The Innsmouth ending, in which the narrator learns that he is what he feared, and the counter-writings of Chapter 9, which rebuild the feared Outside as an inhabited world, confirm it.

12.6 *Sixth Theorem: The Thalassal Telos*

> *Horror is the censored form of a desire for the Outside. Xenophobia is the conscious affect of the Lovecraftian tale; xenophilia is its narrative destination.*

The theorem derives from the pattern of crossings traced in Chapter 9: the Outsider riding with the ghouls, Kuranes reigning in Celephaïs, Carter passing into Yog-Sothoth, Wilmarth tempted by the voyage to Yuggoth, and the Innsmouth narrator descending to dwell amid wonder and glory. It draws on Ferenczi's thalassal regressive trend, Freud's oceanic feeling and death drive, and Otto's analysis of the numinous as *fascinans* as well as *tremendum*, and it is confirmed from outside Lovecraft by the metamorphic postures of Ballard and VanderMeer, Morton's passage from dark-depressing to dark-sweet, and Haraway's tentacular kinship.

COROLLARY Metamorphosis, the third term of the Lovecraftian trilemma, is not an escape from the necronomic situation but its libidinal truth.

OBJECTION AND REPLY The exaltation of the Innsmouth ending may be read as the final horror, the narrator's joy being the measure of his corruption. The reply is that the ironic reading requires a stable standpoint from which the joy can be judged monstrous, and the tale has just demonstrated that no such standpoint exists, since the judging subject is himself a Marsh. The pattern, moreover, recurs across tales of widely different tone and period, from "Celephaïs" to "Through the Gates of the Silver Key," with a consistency that irony does not explain.

12.7 *Seventh Theorem: Necronomic Modernity*

> *The present has universalized the Lovecraftian situation. Deep time, the extinction horizon, the Anthropocene, and the delegation of correlation to non-human systems have made the law of the dead the ordinary condition of knowledge, and weird fiction the realism of the age.*

Four conditions support the theorem. The first is the normalization of deep time. The arche-fossil is no longer an exotic philosophical problem but a routine product of radiometric laboratories and of cosmology, which since the detection of the cosmic microwave background in 1965 has measured a universe some thirteen billion years older than any observer. The second is the Anthropocene. Paul Crutzen and Eugene Stoermer proposed the term in 2000 to name an epoch in which humanity has become a geological agent, and although the stratigraphic subcommission charged with the question declined in 2024 to formalize it as an epoch, the concept has already accomplished its conceptual work. Humanity now imagines itself as a stratum. Jan Zalasiewicz's *The Earth After Us* (2008) asks what geologists of a hundred million years hence would find of us in the rocks, and the question places humanity exactly where Dyer found the Elder Things: our cities are the future R'lyeh, and we are the arche-archive of someone else's expedition.

The third condition is the institutionalization of extinction as an object of knowledge. The sixth mass extinction, documented for a general readership in Elizabeth Kolbert's *The Sixth Extinction* (2014), and the research program on existential risk inaugurated by Nick Bostrom's essay of 2002 have made the world-without-us a matter of policy analysis. What Lovecraft's narrators glimpsed at the moment of madness is now a subject of grant applications.

The fourth condition is delegated correlation, analyzed in Chapter 7. The inability of the human mind to correlate its contents has been supplemented by systems that correlate at a scale no human synthesizer could approach, and among these are statistical language systems trained on vast archives of human writing, a large part of it composed by the dead. Such a system generates text in no one's voice from the regularities of an archive it did not live through. The epigraph of *The Case of Charles Dexter Ward*, with its dream of preparing the essential salts of human dust so that the shape of any ancestor may be called up for interrogation, is the most exact premodern image of such a system, and Lovecraft's false etymology of the *Necronomicon*, an image of the law of the

dead, reads with uncomfortable literalness as a description of a model derived from the archived utterances of the dead. This dissertation takes no position on the capacities or dangers of such systems. It observes only that they instantiate, with structural exactness, correlation without a correlator and an archive that answers. The Shining Trapezohedron of "The Haunter of the Dark," described in its victim's notes as a window on all time and space, which summons what it shows whenever it is left in darkness, is the Mythos's figure for the interface at which such an archive addresses an individual.

COROLLARY Weird fiction is the realism of the present. Amitav Ghosh's *The Great Derangement* (2016) argues that the serious novel has failed to represent climate change because the events it produces are so improbable that the conventions of realism exclude them as the stuff of genre. The weird, the genre of the improbable-but-lawful, of events that violate expectation without violating physics, inherits the task realism has abandoned.

OBJECTION AND REPLY The theorem appears to make Lovecraft a prophet and to commit the fallacy of presentism. The reply is that no prediction is claimed. Lovecraft formalized a structure, the aperture and its breach by correlation, the defended interior and its autoimmune dissolution, the myth that exposes and its re-domestication, and the present instantiates that structure because the conditions that produced it in the 1920s, the collision of scientific disclosure with a creature fitted for a niche, have intensified rather than passed. Structures outlive their occasions.

The seven theorems define necronomics as the study of how a creature of *nomos* lives under *physis*: what it can know, how knowing breaks it, how it tells stories about what breaks it, how it defends itself, what it secretly desires, and how its situation has become general. They describe; they do not prescribe. The Conclusion turns to the question they leave open, which is what such a creature should do.



The Lovecraftian Trilemma and the Unwritten Fourth Tale

This dissertation has argued that Lovecraft's work constitutes a necronomics: a speculative theory of what holds in the absence of the knower, of the aperture that protects the knower from it, of the correlation that breaches the aperture, of the myth that exposes rather than consoles, of the defended interior that discovers itself constituted by the Outside, and of the desire that the horror censors. Part One traced its genealogy through atomism, astronomy, evolutionary theory, philosophy, and the weird tradition; Part Two formalized its mechanisms; Part Three situated it among the postures that philosophical science fiction and contemporary philosophy have taken toward the same predicament; Part Four stated its theorems and argued that the present has made the Lovecraftian situation general. The theorems describe; they do not prescribe. It remains to ask what the argument implies for conduct, and the question returns the study to the paragraph from which it began.

The Trilemma

The founding paragraph of "The Call of Cthulhu" names two exits from the revelation it anticipates: we shall either go mad or flee from the deadly light into the peace and safety of a new dark age. The fiction adds a third, which the paragraph does not name but the tales repeatedly enact: metamorphosis, the passage of the knower into what he knows, from the Outsider's ride with the ghouls to the Innsmouth narrator's descent. These three form the Lovecraftian trilemma. *At the Mountains of Madness* contains all three within a single narrative. Danforth, who looks back at the farther range, goes mad and survives as a voice that repeats fragments of the Mythos without syntax. Dyer writes his account for the explicit purpose of dissuading the Starkweather-Moore expedition from returning to the Antarctic, asking the scientific world to renounce a knowledge it could otherwise obtain: a voluntary new dark age, the aperture narrowed by choice. And Dyer's judgment that the Elder Things were men is a metamorphosis, not of the body but of the category, in which the human is redefined to include the alien that made it.

The trilemma maps with unsettling precision onto the principal responses to the planetary situation described by the seventh theorem. The first exit corresponds to the distress recorded under the names of eco-anxiety and solastalgia, the latter coined by the philosopher Glenn Albrecht in 2005 for the homesickness of those whose home is changing around them. Researchers have stressed, rightly, that such distress is a proportionate response to real information rather than a disorder, which is exactly the status of the Lovecraftian narrator's madness. The second exit corresponds to what the sociologist Kari Marie Norgaard, in *Living in Denial* (2011), called socially organized denial: a community that possesses the knowledge of climate change and organizes its emotional and conversational life so as not to integrate it. Norgaard's community is Lovecraft's placid island, maintaining its dissociation collectively, and James Bridle's *New Dark Age* (2018), whose title echoes Lovecraft's phrase, extends the diagnosis to an information environment in which more data yield less understanding. The third exit corresponds to the posthuman programs, ecological and technological. Haraway's multispecies kinship and VanderMeer's acceptance are its ecological form; the aspiration to leave the biological body behind, which the brain cylinders of "The Whisperer in Darkness" anticipated with ironic exactness, is its technological form. Each exit

has its advocates, and each, as the fiction shows, costs the one who takes it something essential. Madness costs agency, the dark age costs truth, and metamorphosis costs the self that was to be saved.

The Fourth Path: Lucid Correlation

The fiction offers no fourth exit, but the life does. Chapter 1 established that Lovecraft distributed the two halves of Nagel's absurd across two persons: the author who achieved the view from nowhere with equanimity, and the narrator who was destroyed by it. The typology of Chapter 10 located the author in the cell of ataraxia and the narrator in the cell of horror, and observed that the gap between them was never closed in the tales. This dissertation names the posture that would close it *lucid correlation*: the capacity to perform the synthesis the founding paragraph dreaded, to hold the law of the dead in view, without madness, without flight, and without the surrender of the self.

Lucid correlation has four components, each drawn from a figure this study has examined and each insufficient alone. The first is Epicurean ataraxia, which Lovecraft practiced in his letters: the recognition that indifference is not malice, so that the Old Ones, however vast, intend nothing, and a cosmos that intends nothing gives no occasion for the specific terror of being hated. Alone, ataraxia risks the author's detachment, serene in private while the narrators break in public. The second is Camusian lucidity, the refusal of every consoling leap and the decision to live in full awareness of the situation without converting it into hope. Alone, it risks the heroic solitude of revolt. The third is the humility of Lem's Solaristics: a science that knows its categories to be anthropomorphic, maps its aperture from within, and persists in inquiry without expecting inquiry to end in possession. Alone, it risks an endless melancholy. The fourth is Leopardi's solidarity, the confederation of all who share the situation against the indifference that threatens them, extended, as the counter-writings of Chapter 9 extend it, to every being that has a world. Alone, it risks becoming a new tribalism of the human.

Joined, the four components answer the three exits. Against madness, lucid correlation sets ataraxia: the knowledge that the law of the dead is not addressed to us and therefore cannot condemn us. Against the new dark age, it sets lucidity and humility: the refusal to purchase peace with ignorance, together with the admission that knowledge will always be partial. Against metamorphosis, it sets solidarity: not the dissolution of the self into the Outside

but the widening of the interior to include what the Outside had been taken to contain. The fourth path does not deny the premises of the trilemma. It accepts that the aperture is narrow, that correlation is dangerous, and that the interior is constituted by the Outside. It denies only that these truths must be lived as horror.

The Unwritten Tale

Lovecraft never wrote the tale of lucid correlation, but the biographical record suggests that he lived its final chapter. He died in Providence on 15 March 1937, at the age of forty-six, of cancer of the small intestine, and his biographers report that during his last illness he kept notes on his symptoms for his physicians for as long as he could hold a pen. The final document of the writer who spent his career imagining narrators destroyed by the knowledge of their own dissolution appears to have been a clinical record of his, composed in the spirit of observation rather than dread. The tales end in italics; the life ended, so far as the record allows us to say, in the plain prose of a case history.

The headstone placed by admirers at Swan Point Cemetery in 1977 bears a phrase from one of his letters: I AM PROVIDENCE. The inscription unites the two laws of the dead that Chapter 4 distinguished. It names a city, the ancestral *nomos* to which Lovecraft pledged himself, and it names in the same word the theological providence his cosmos denied. A creature of *nomos*, buried under *physis*, is identified with a place and with the absence of a plan. The epitaph is the *Necronomicon* in three words.

This study began with Lucretius, whose Epicurus crossed the flaming walls of the world and returned to report that knowledge of nature abolishes fear. Lovecraft inverted the promise: at the scale modern science disclosed, knowledge of nature became the source of fear. The argument of necronomics permits the inversion to be inverted once more, not by shrinking the cosmos to fit the knower, but by transforming the knower's relation to the cosmos. The walls have been crossed again, by telescopes, by radiometric clocks, by the correlating machines of the present, and the return need be neither Lucretius's triumph nor Thurston's catastrophe. It can be lucid. That is the fourth tale, the one Lovecraft lived and did not write, and it is the ethical horizon of a necronomic modernity: to know the law of the dead, to live by the law of the living, and to widen, patiently, the circle of those to whom the second applies.

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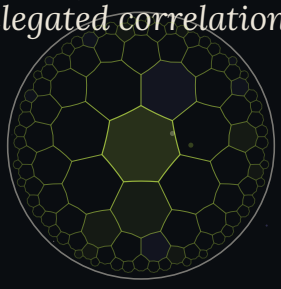
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Keywords

H. P. Lovecraft ◆ *cosmicism* ◆ *cosmic indifferentism* ◆ *necronomics* ◆ *law of the dead* ◆ *nomos and physis* ◆ *weird fiction* ◆ *supernatural horror* ◆ *merciful aperture* ◆ *correlation* ◆ *correlationism* ◆ *arche-fossil* ◆ *Umwelt* ◆ *Reizschutz* ◆ *mechanistic materialism* ◆ *Epicureanism* ◆ *Democritean atomism* ◆ *the sublime* ◆ *abjection* ◆ *degeneration theory* ◆ *the abhuman* ◆ *deep time* ◆ *non-Euclidean geometry* ◆ *the fourth dimension* ◆ *Copernican decentering* ◆ *Schopenhauerian pessimism* ◆ *Nietzschean perspectivism* ◆ *Spenglerian decline* ◆ *counter-mythology* ◆ *work on myth* ◆ *Gnosticism* ◆ *the numinous* ◆ *immunitas* ◆ *autoimmunity* ◆ *racial anxiety* ◆ *thalassal telos* ◆ *death drive* ◆ *documentary form* ◆ *media archaeology* ◆ *philosophical science fiction* ◆ *cognitive estrangement* ◆ *negative novum* ◆ *speculative realism* ◆ *object-oriented ontology* ◆ *the weird and the eerie* ◆ *horror of philosophy* ◆ *dark ecology* ◆ *hyperobjects* ◆ *Chthulucene* ◆ *Anthropocene* ◆ *extinction* ◆ *posthumanism* ◆ *delegated correlation* ◆ *lucid correlation*



SET IN LORA AND POPPINS

PLATES: THE {7,3} TILING OF THE HYPERBOLIC PLANE · STRATA · APERTURE · ORBITS · HEPTAGRAM